

CULTURES OF KARRNATH

THE BLADE OF GALIFAR

JOSEPH MEEHAN

Bringing Karrnath to (un)life like never before!



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ON THE COVER

Atur, the City of Night, by Olie Boldador. The sun has dipped below the horizon but trailing light illuminates the sky over the Ashen Spires. In the left background sits the Crimson Monastery, a gigantic blood-red pyramid. In the foreground is an airship docking tower bearing the Kraken sigilry of House Lyrandar.

Disclaimer: The Code of Kaius is strict, and visitors to Karrnath are warned to watch their step; those who stray are likely to end up in front of a military tribunal.

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HISTORY

Like much of Khorvaire, Karnath's ancient history is still the subject of active archaeological investigation. The nation's known history begins with a clash between the Dhakaani Empire and the dwarves of Sol Udar, with the goblinoids of Dhakaan proving victorious and claiming all the land west of the Ironroot Mountains. Prior settlements and civilizations are largely unknown, more the subject of rumor and theory than strong historical evidence; roll on the Ancient Legends table for option. Some scholars have taken interest in the oral traditions of the Talentan halflings, but few appreciate the accuracy of these nomadic groups' historic knowledge.

ANCIENT LEGENDS

d4 Rumor

- 1 Scions Sound isn't a natural feature but was carved during the ancient battles between dragons and demons.
- 2 The Ashen Spires mark the spot of a titanic battle in Khyber; the force of the battle echoed upwards to raise the mountains on the surface.
- 3 The Dhakaani angered the Forest Queen with their forges, so she tore down their civilization in retribution.
- 4 Humans lived in Khorvaire before the goblins and built the foundations of the cities that the goblins only expanded on. They fled to Sarlona to escape some ancient disaster.

THE FOUNDING

Humanity arrived through the mouth of Scions Sound a few hundred years after Lhazaar's arrival in the east in -2000 YK. These early years were defined by bloody conflicts with the goblins who already lived on the lands, with humans winning successive conflicts and carving space for themselves. As time went on, these human settlements grew into kingdoms of their own, warring against each other for territory and pride. This changed with the coming of Karn in -1000 YK. Born in Karrlakton, Karn led his kingdom's forces to conquer Korth then the rest of the human kingdoms of the region, a unifying force that founded the modern nation of Karnath.

Karn, however, was not sated, and set his eyes on his neighbor to the southwest—the Kingdom of Metrol. Floating his army down the Cyre River, he successfully captured the capital and laid claim to the entire kingdom. This aggression united the kingdoms of Daskara, Thaliost, and Wroat against him. Karn's defeat freed the Kingdom of Metrol, but the nation he forged—Karnath—kept its feudal bonds of loyalty to Korth, the new capital. These lands extended south through the modern Talenta Plains, with the Blade Desert forming its southern border.

Karn's attempts to conquer the continent would go on to inspire many future kings to do the same, although none succeeded until Galifar united the Five Nations a thousand years later. Karnathi border skirmishes with Thaliost and Metrol were common, and even today the Karnathi countryside is littered with the remains of this ancient warfare, with archaic battlements designed long before the advent of everyday magic and its strategic implications.

THE WAR OF THE MARK

When Karn attempted to conquer the continent, the dragonmarked families had not yet united into great houses. His assault not only unified individual nations, but the dragonmarked families also bound themselves together in grand alliances. During that same period, the presence of aberrant dragonmarks grew. In Karnath, both House Deneith and House Jorasco sounded the alarm about the danger of these aberrant marks and convened a summit of the ten existing dragonmarked houses—the Mark of Warding was not yet known to the rest of Khorvaire, and the Mark of Finding had not yet manifested in the Shadow Marches.

Whether through genuine fear or the self-serving need of a scapegoat to distinguish between the "good" and "bad" marks, this summit launched the bloody purge of aberrant-marked individuals from the five nations that is now known as the War of the Mark. Deneith enforcers rounded up aberrant-marked individuals and passed them along to House Jorasco to remove their marks. When this proved impossible, the prisoners were put to death. The houses were largely united in their purge, with Vadalis tracking hounds supplementing Medani inquisitives and Deneith soldiers; among the houses only House Ghallanda had a substantive number of dissenters, many of whom were exiled or worse when they saved aberrant-marked individuals from execution.

While the aberrant-marked eventually rallied and made a stand in Sharn, there was no such organized armed resistance in Karnath; while most Karnathi today know only the propagandized version of the houses valiantly defending the common people from a marauding army of aberrant-marked monsters, the dragonmarked of Karnath were the first and most ruthless in their efforts to slaughter people with aberrant marks.

At the conclusion of the war, Baron Hadran d'Cannith proposed that the houses should unify and found a research institute in Korth. The architect and artificer Alder d'Cannith, whose inventions had played a critical role in the war, proposed that the organization be named the Twelve, as while only ten marks were known at the time, he believed that a total of twelve true dragonmarks would flow through living blood. This belief was vindicated a millennium later when House Tharashk was finally inducted into the Twelve in the year 498 YK.

GALIFAR

Galifar ir'Wynarn was born a thousand years after Karn in the same city of Karrlakton. He rose to be the King of Karnath not through raw force, but through political guile as he navigated the politicking warlords. One of his key diplomatic insights was to offer exclusive status to the Dragonmarked Houses, negotiating directly with the Twelve and establishing the Korth edicts; the houses would have favored economic status within his new kingdom so long as they supported it.

Galifar's second key diplomatic insight was to offer liberation to the goblinoid peoples of Khorvaire. While Karn had eradicated the goblinoid population within his own nation's borders, goblinoids lived on in the rest of the continent as slaves and slum-dwellers. Galifar pledged to free the enslaved peoples of any nation he conquered and coordinated with the descendants of successful uprisings over the past millennia that various goblinoid populations

had staged. Whether Galifar's actions were taken out of genuine concern for liberty or raw political interest is still a matter of scholarly debate; the king did little to ensure freed peoples could economically succeed in his new empire, sowing the seeds of the modern state of goblinoid marginalization across Khorvaire.

THE KINGDOM OF GALIFAR

Upon ascending to the throne, Galifar ir'Wynarn appointed each of his five children to govern a different nation. Karrn, the third of the King's children, was given his homeland of Karrnath and instructed to found a premier school to train the new kingdom's military officers. Karrn and his new spouse, the Archduke of Karrlakton, founded Rekkenmark Academy, an effort which was later supported and expanded upon by Galifar's heir, King Cyre.

The first true challenge for the fresh officers of Rekkenmark and Prince Karrn was to conquer the Mror Holds. Through both military might and diplomacy, Karrn split the Mroran clans and successfully annexed the land between the Ironroot and Hoarfrost mountain ranges. The dwarves were incorporated into Karrnath as a grand duchy and were left to self-rule so long as they paid their tribute and taxes.

The intermediate period of Karrnathi history was filled with minor squabbles, uprisings, and other political and sociological events; perhaps the most significant of these was the terror sown by the necromancers of the Talons of Ice led by the reclusive elvish necromancer, Lady Illmarrow, in the middle of the 6th century. Prior to this, only the foremost scholars and diplomats of Khorvaire knew of Lady Illmarrow, but the horrors the Talons unleashed entered her into household legends. The combined forces of the knights of Dol Arrah, templars of the Silver Flame, and the Karrnathi military defeated the Talons of Ice, but the terrors unleashed by the Talons set the stage for Lady Illmarrow's later intervention into Karrnathi life.

The 9th century brought significant disruptions to Khorvaire's economy, as a young King Jarot presided over the construction of the lightning rail lines that now crisscross Karrnath. These lines transformed rural Karrnath in unprecedented ways—both trade and information could traverse the continent in weeks rather than months. *The Korranberg Chronicle* established itself as the continental paper of record during this time, expanding from its traditional big-city markets into rural communities, while those rural communities could now sell their cheese and ale to the wider kingdom. These changes also launched the first true middle class in Khorvaire, as independent merchants made money facilitating these newfound connections.

THE LAST WAR

Kaius I, the third of Jarot's five children, spent his formative years as prince of Karrnath implementing his father's visions for a secure Galifar; he solidified his rule over the warlords, bolstered the army, and tended to the overall integrity of the realm. As his father grew late in years, he conspired with his older brother Thalin, the governor-prince of Thrane, to usurp the throne of Galifar's line of succession from their eldest sister, Mishann, who ruled over Cyre; while he never admitted it publicly, Khorvairian scholars today generally agree that

Kaius I supported Thalin's claim insofar as it was the only path for Kaius himself to claim the Galifaran throne.

Alongside declaring Karrnath's independence and himself King, Kaius instituted a new system of laws known as the Code of Kaius. Mandatory military service rapidly filled the ranks of Karrnath's armies, which immediately marched on both Aundair and Cyre. The alliance with Thrane and Breland held at first, in part due to their geographic distance; no need to antagonize countries too far away to make war against anyways.

Unfortunately, the early years of the war were disastrous for Kaius's war machine; for all his work strengthening the armies of Karrnath, chronic plagues and famine ensured they could not simply march through Aundair and Cyre as the self-appointed king had envisioned. Unbeknownst to the public at the time, Lady Illmarrow of Farnen approached Kaius with a deal—she would bring an end to the famines and plagues so long as Kaius made the Blood of Vol the state religion and established the Order of the Emerald Claw as a knightly order. Kaius took the deal in 896 YK, but when he attempted to institute his own controls on the Order, Lady Illmarrow murdered his wife in retribution. Kaius I died in 910 YK from a mysterious illness, which was later alleged to be another consequence of his resistance to Lady Illmarrow.

In 914 YK, just four years into Kaius II's rule, the dwarven clans united under the Iron Council and declared independence from Karrnath. Wracked by famine and plague, the Karrnathi army could not regain control of the region, and the crown was ultimately forced to diplomatically recognize the dwarven government. This humiliation also struck a blow to the nation's war coffers, as Karrnath had long profited from dwarven taxes and the mountain's riches.

Towards the end of Kaius II's reign, in 956 YK, Valenar declared its independence from Cyre. While Tairnadal mercenaries had long fought Karrnath under Cyre's banner, their new role as an independent state intensified this conflict. Battles between Karrnath and Valenar scarred the Talenta Plains, where the halflings began to realize that the tribes could not ensure peace on their lands while acting separately. Years later, Jaron, the successor to and son of Kaius II, was able to make some diplomatic inroads with High King Shaeras Vadallia of Valenar and buy off the raiders on his southern border to redirect them at Aundair and Cyre.

Jaron's sudden death in 972 YK elevated his sister Moranna to the status of regent, as none of his heirs were of age. In 976 YK, a few years into her rule, Moranna revealed the duplicity of the Order of the Emerald Claw—that they secretly served Lady Illmarrow as their true master—and reinstated the Sovereign Host as the state religion of Karrnath. Lady Illmarrow was declared an enemy of the state, her crimes and conspiracies exposed in special editions of Karrnath's newspapers. The various Seeker chivalric orders were disbanded, but the Order of the Emerald claw—the oldest and most powerful of them—adapted and survived as a terrorist organization, turning its talents against Moranna and her allies.

The tail end of Moranna's reign was troubled, with the nation increasingly finding itself on the backfoot. No event represents that more than the 989 sacking of Narath, when the Aundairians razed the city to the ground. Other setbacks, both diplomatically and militarily, left Karrnath isolated and conceding territorial gains made within Cyre.

Kaius III came of age in 991 YK, assuming the throne from his aunt. His primary challenge as a new, young king was uniting a country in turmoil. Traditionally, young monarchs would secure an alliance by marrying the scion of a duke, binding that duchy to the throne; Kaius, after courting several possible pairings, instead chose to marry Etrigani, an Aereni diplomat. Despite the initial whispers amongst the nobility, Kaius and Etrigani are now considered to have been a love match, rather than some purely political ploy.

Despite the nation's martial culture, Karrnath was a key proponent of the Treaty of Thronehold. Many of his warlords groaned and dissented, but King Kaius pushed on nonetheless, working with King Boranel and the six-year-old Keeper Jaela to persuade Queen Aurala to come to the negotiating table; once the remaining claimants to the throne of Galifar began negotiations, the other nations were plenty willing to join in. Of course, the elves of Valenar seem to have little respect for the papers they signed, with warbands continuing to attack southern Karrnath with the thinnest deniability.

Broadly speaking, how one views the territorial concessions of the treaty strongly influences one's opinion of King Kaius III; the Mror Holds, Talenta Plains, Lhazaar Principalities, and Q'barra were all technically Karrnathi territory prior to the war, so if one views their independence as a temporary blip, then Kaius displayed weakness by formally recognizing them as nations. If those nations' independence is seen as a true reflection of their people and history, then Kaius was recognizing objective political history rather than wish casting for the glory of an imperial past.

THE TRUTH

This summary of Karrnath's history is reasonably public information; while any given character might not know every detail (just as people IRL often don't know every aspect of history), nothing presented here is *secret* information. As such, any aspect of it could be subject to conspiracy theories or even true secretive conspiracies; Drago Thul, an exiled general who now lives in Stormreach, publicly accused Kaius III of secretly being a vampiric Kaius I. Similarly, the love between Etrigani and Kaius could simply be part of a deeper deception.

This supplement several times assumes the 3.5 canon that Kaius III is secretly a vampiric Kaius I, but the person of Kaius is not a focus of this supplement. Variations, such as [Kaius III secretly posing as Kaius I](#) [posing as Kaius III](#), are certainly possible and can be used to keep players familiar with the older canon on their toes.



RELIGION

Karnath is known throughout the Five Nations for its practice of the Blood of Vol; its status as the state religion for most of the war was embodied by news coverage of its undead armies and macabre priests. Moranna stripped this status over twenty years ago, but this resulted in little change to Karnath's military reliance on the undead, and so international perception did not shift accordingly.

Now that the war has ended, Kaius has made a show of supporting the Sovereign Host and has even outright banned the open worship of the Blood of Vol within Korth.

Demographics. If you gathered twenty random Karnns, eleven would profess to be Vassals of the Sovereign Host; another six Seekers of the Divinity Within; two would profess no faith at all; and the twentieth would practice some other faith, such as Talentan spiritualism, the Church of the Silver Flame, or even the Path of Light.

THE BLOOD OF VOL

Historically a fringe cult, fewer than one in ten Karnnathi citizens were Seekers before the Last War. State support of the Blood of Vol over the span of eighty years dramatically increased this number, and by the time Moranna took the throne as regent in 973 about five in ten Karnnathi citizens identified with the faith. Shocking revelations about horrific practices and the stripping of its official status immediately shook the faith of many, and the population of its practitioners has continued to gradually decline to reach its current levels of about three in ten.

DOCTRINE

Seekers of the Blood of Vol are incredibly diverse in their specific beliefs, but one mantra unites them: That *only the divine is eternal*. Dollurh is not a gateway to some mysterious afterlife with the sovereigns—it leads to *oblivion*. It is from this core conviction that all other beliefs follow.

When it comes to the sovereigns, Seekers are split as to whether the sovereigns “truly exist;” if they do, the sovereigns are cruel deities who do not deserve worship. The most stalwart believers hold that the sovereigns are not just indifferent to the plight of mortals but have actively pulled the ladder up by denying common people the secrets of true divinity. However, despite their opinions about the sovereigns, most Seekers are simply indifferent to Vassals, seeing any manifestation of divine magic as an expression of the innate power of living beings—the Divinity Within—rather than proof the Sovereign Host exists.

While some might point to the resistance to abstract deities as a commonality between the Blood of Vol and the Church of the Silver Flame, the practical reality of each faith leaves them as anathema to each other. The Blood of Vol denies that *any* outside power, even a seemingly benevolent one like the Silver Flame, can be trusted and worthy of worship; by contrast, the Church of the Silver Flame categorically rejects that any undead should be tolerated and lived alongside.

UNDEAD

The typical Seeker does not *want* to become undead; it's a half-measure at best, as undead lack the spark of life that

is required for true divinity. Instead, the undead are tools. Reanimation as a zombie or skeleton allows your soul to pass into the oblivion of Dollurh while your body serves your community. Becoming a vampire, oathbound mummy, or other form of sapient undead is still ultimately seen as a *service* to the community, enduring the agony of undeath to provide others with more direct long-term guidance.

One of Moranna's revelations in 976 was that the undead members of the church were not acting in service but were instead preying upon the faithful like cattle. Her publicity tour included a few public vampire executions, a brutal culling that shockingly revealed some nobility had secretly passed into unlife while continuing to rule (a violation of not just the Code of Kaius, but the Code of Galifar). Seekers today range from denying Moranna's allegations about the undead, to downplaying them as “a few bad apples”, to outright accusing the former regent of fabricating evidence as part of a political power play against the faithful.

HIERARCHY

Unlike the Church of the Silver Flame, the modern Blood of Vol lacks a strong system of hierarchy; local faith leaders, known as abactors, have significant freedom. Some of this is because up until the 9th century and the invention of the lightning rail, rural Karnnathi Seeker communities had few ways to communicate with each other; rituals, rites, and practices were developed largely independently in response to local conditions. While some abactors might be considered particularly wise or well-gifted in faith (especially elven or undead ones who led congregations over the course of centuries), an abactor cannot *force* another into compliance through religious authority; they only have the tools of public and private persuasion.

This is a sharp contrast to the Blood of Vol's structure while it was the state religion. Abactors were tightly tied to their local nobility, Karnath's feudal rulers were wise to heed an abactor's guidance and insight. Part of Moranna's revelations were that many abactors secretly reported to Lady Illmarrow, using their positions to guide Karnath according to her malign will. While the initial paranoia has mostly faded, the first few years of Moranna's purge were a dangerous time as demagogic warlords whipped up crowds against Seeker faith leaders.

THE CRIMSON COVENANT

While the typical abactor does not receive directions from anyone, some, such as High Priest Malevanor of Atur, answer to a secret council of undead known as the Crimson Covenant. The group's existence has become a matter of public rumor since Moranna's repudiation of the religion, but the details of its membership are the subject of conspiracy theories; some suggest that the Crimson Covenant are direct agents of Lady Illmarrow, others suggest they're interlopers from Mababar or Dollurh. Some even say that when a powerful member of the faithful uses a divination spell like *commune*, the divine proxy that answers is one of the Crimson Covenant.

In truth, the Crimson Covenant is a group of thirteen former mortals founded well before Lady Illmarrow took an interest in the Blood of Vol, with several members older than the Kingdom of Galifar and its head, the demilich Duran, older than *Karnath*. Over the centuries,

Illmarrow's agents infiltrated the group, ensuring it would be pliable when the time came for her to dominate Karnath. Moranna's revelations about the lich's influence have shaken the members of the Covenant, who no longer trust each other as they question their relationship both to the faith and to the political divisions within Karnath. Some within the Covenant argue that Lady Illmarrow is an important patron the group should try to work with; others argue that she has given herself fully to the power of Mabar and must be opposed.

The majority of the Crimson Covenant members reside within Atur as oathbound mummies alongside their leader Duran. Some of the other members, such as the Silent Knight, are free to leave the city. For more on oathbound mummies and the Silent Knight check out [Chronicles of Eberron](#) by Keith Baker.

PRACTICES

Look not to the skies, nor to the depths below, nor even to the distant past or future. Seek the divine within, for the blood is the life, and in its call can be heard the promise of life eternal. One has but to listen.

Creed of the Blood of Vol

The Sacrament of Blood is a cornerstone of the Blood of Vol; each month, practitioners gather to donate blood via an enchanted dagger known as a *bloodfang*. This blood is then stored in *preserving casks* for use in rituals unique to the faith. During this ceremony, participants recite the creed, affirming their commitment to their community over any outside gods. This ceremony also gathers the community, allowing for the exchange of news and gossip before and after. The abactor who leads the ceremony typically prepares a speech to give after the sacrament, with topics ranging from mundane community concerns like the military to abstract theology like the nature of the soul. After the speech, the community discusses the ideas presented and enjoys a shared meal.

Childbirth is an important event within Seeker communities, as the act of bringing someone new into the world is both an act of defiance and a submission to the grand cycle of life and death. Seekers place great emphasis on genealogical records; while the Blood of Vol was the state religion, every Karnathi citizen learned their heritage out to at least four generations. Whether a child is within the context of a marriage or not is far less

BLOODFANG

Weapon (dagger), common

Developed in conjunction with House Jorasco, these daggers are enchanted to instantly clean and knit wounds. As an action, a creature can make a blood offering with this dagger, taking 1d4 points of slashing damage and gaining that many temporary hit points in addition to any ritualistic benefits of the offering.

PRESERVING CASK

Wondrous item, common

Developed in conjunction with House Ghallanda, these casks prevent contamination, fermentation, evaporation, and coagulation. It does not purify already contaminated liquids.

important than maintaining true and accurate records of familial relations; furthermore, Jorasco's magic has made surrogacy and other manipulations much easier, meaning that even non-heterosexual and/or non-cis couples can have children together.

Within Seeker communities, children who can menstruate have an important coming of age ceremony following their first blood. The ceremony doubles both as a recognition of the growth and change that comes with menstruation, but also a test of magical aptitude; the items used in the ceremony react to children with potential for divine magic, and those that show magical ability are offered a new life path to harness that power. Their transition into adulthood is celebrated by the whole community in a party that lasts well into the night; during the war, this was one of the few exceptions to the curfews the nation lived under.

Unusually, Seeker communities do not place much importance on weddings. While Seekers do partake in the institution, ceremonies are the subject of local traditions and strongly influenced by other cultural factors, such as the fey or holdovers from worship of the Sovereign Host.

Funerals are major events in Seeker communities, as the deceased is honored for their life's work and their body is publicly prepared to continue to assist the living. Some are raised as *oathbound*—wrapped in linen and mummified—but most are simply raised as basic zombies or skeletons, their corpses providing manual labor for the community. The funeral ceremony is a celebration of the life of the person, but its contrast with the objectification of the corpse is often jarring for those not familiar with the faith.

One of the Blood of Vol's most critical practices is entirely divorced from the lives of individuals. Mabaran manifest zones are common within Karnath. Normally these areas are hostile to life, but their blighting effect on the lands near and within them can be defused by channeling the necrotic energy they generate into other purposes. The most common of these is the reanimation of a community's dead; while not as quick and combat ready as the *animate dead* spell, this process reliably produces simple undead that are capable of following orders without the killer instinct of a zombie or skeleton that was spontaneously reanimated. Other rituals similarly harness the negative energy to create magic items or perform useful magic, cumulatively reducing the impact of the zone and allowing for agriculture and other forms of life.

HOLIDAYS

The Blood of Vol celebrates only a single holiday, Revelation Day, on the 13th of Zarantyr. This special sacrament of blood involves the abactor leading the ceremony purifying the blood, which is then passed back around the congregation to imbibe. Recipients often experience visions and waking dreams, but it's up to them to interpret their meaning. One of Moranna's disclosures in 976 was that abactors would sometimes manipulate the ritual to their own or others' ends; this corruption of such an important ritual has significantly contributed to the shedding of the faith over the last two decades.

THE CULT OF LIFE

Perhaps the most sinister aspects of the Blood of Vole revealed by Moranna's in 976 was the existence of the Cult of Life, a sect that embraces the use of profane magic to

ensure their personal immortality. A series of highly publicized trials revealed that high-ranking members promised knowledge of dark magic to lower-ranking members in exchange for not just services but blood donations. Furthermore, some high-ranking members mixed their worship of the Divinity Within with other dark powers, such as the Dark Six or various overlords. Despite this, some branches of the Cult of Life have persisted not just in Karrnath but outside the nation; appeals to desperation, narcissism, or a simple need for community have fertile soil in the war-torn continent of Khorvaire.

THE BLOOD OF DORN

The Last War brought about a new form of Vassal-Seeker syncretism known as the Blood of Dorn. Vassal soldiers would often cut themselves before a challenge or battle as a blood offering to Dol Dorn for strength and victory. The advent of the Blood of Vol as the state religion led many soldiers to mix the two religion's practices, sprinkled in with some mysticism about "rituals first used by the Mae-Khree warriors of ancient Syrkarn." Despite the historical illiteracy of these beliefs, they have nevertheless manifested genuine miracles. Simon Vince is the most vocal leader of this group, a khoravar veteran who's started his own mercenary company that contracts out through House Deneith's Blademarks Guild.



THE SOVEREIGN HOST

The most popular religion in Karrnath, worship of the Sovereign Host influences every aspect of Karrnathi culture. Even during the 80-year period in which the Blood of Vol was the state religion, streets, buildings, and businesses were still named after the sovereigns. While events may have taken on a more secular bent, foregoing explicit prayer, the fundamental structure of Karrnathi life is tied up with belief in the sovereigns.

DOCTRINE

While Karrnathi Vassals worship the same nine and acknowledge the same six as others in the rest of Khorvaire, they emphasize each deity's portfolio somewhat differently and have a different understanding of the gods' familial relations.

Aureon is still the god of law and magic, but order is emphasized far more than knowledge. The Nulakeshi creed holds that Aureon's spouse is Dol Dorn, whose strength at arms defends the family. Their children are Dol Arrah and the Mockery, although recognition of the latter as Dol Azur is far more common in Karrnath than other nations. Karrn Vassals are far more willing to recognize Aureon and Dol Dorn as joint heads of the pantheon than Vassals of other nations, who insist on equality between members of the pantheon.

Meanwhile, Onatar (who is still Aureon's brother) is wed to Boldrei, as the flame of civilization fuels both his forge and her hearth. The couple's children are still Kol Korran and the Keeper, whose connected domains of trade, commerce, and wealth are the fruits of civilization.

The Three Faces of the Wild—Arawai, Balinor, and the Devourer—have the most variance in perception within Karrnath. Regional experiences with famine, inclement weather, and other threats of the wilds uniquely shape perspectives on the deities. Even among three faces mystery cults no two are the same in their understanding of the balance between civilization and the wilds. For example, a group in Vasfold might be a bulette conservation group for and by the well-to-do, while another in Karrlakton might border on ecoterrorism in their opposition to industry.

Finally, Olladra, the lady of fortune, is rarely venerated beyond offerings to the pantheon as a whole. Gambling, cheery entertainment, and even the game of dominoes are disfavored among most Karrns. While risk-taking on the battlefield is a necessary part of the nation's martial culture, Vassals pray to Dol Dorn rather than Olladra when doing so. The main exception to this is among the halflings of southern Karrnath, whose affinity for the goddess has played into her classical depiction as a halfling woman.

HIERARCHY

Until the Year of Blood and Fire that birthed the Church of the Silver Flame, the city of Daskaran in Thrane was the center of Khorvaire's worship of the Sovereign Host. Afterwards, Metrol became the center of worship. Today, after the Day of Mourning, the Cathedral to the Sovereign Host in Korth is the most significant temple in all of Khorvaire. The cathedral's head priest, Prelate Alinda Roerith, was instrumental in defending the city during the third siege of Korth in 971 YK. Her actions established her as a national hero, embodying the blessings of both

Aureon and Dol Dorn. While she lacks full *authority* over the hierarchy of the Karnathi priesthood, the prelate still leads a large congregation, with membership including many of Korth's most prominent nobles who regularly attend services and seek her for guidance—a position that gives her plenty of *power*.

Worship of the Sovereign Host is organized on a temple-by-temple basis. Only the major cities have what can be considered full-time priests; most clergy operate on a part time basis, even if they can cast spells. Priests administer ceremonies, offer guidance, and otherwise work to support their communities in accordance with the principles of the Host as a whole. Larger communities are more likely to have shrines specific to a particular sovereign, while smaller communities simply have a holy symbol affixed to a wall.

Funds come from both donations by the citizenry and direct support from local nobles; during the 80-year period in which the Blood of Vol was the state religion, many temples fell into disrepair and priests had to move full time into their other job. The last twenty-two years have been an important period of restoration for the faith, symbolically led by Prelate Alinda Roerith who has been elevated by the crown as an example to all Karrns.

PRACTICES

One of the reasons even mid-size Host temples need several full-time staff members is the sheer number of rites and rituals the faith practices. The Host is deeply involved in daily life; prayer songs recognize the sovereign's influence, while rites ask for their blessing and offer thanks. Vassals see their faith as strongly color-coded; hunters burn brown and red candles for Balinor, while brides wear orange to honor Boldrei. While priests are not needed for every minor rite, their presence is appreciated and taken as a particular sign of blessing.

Major rites, such as the celebration of the holidays, are only conducted by priests and often involve multiple sovereigns. Sacrifices are common with major rites; harvest offerings to Arawai, manufactured goods are buried or burned for Onatar, and sometimes even animal sacrifices are conducted to invoke the most potent of blessings from any of the deities. These rites are a matter of faith; *detect magic* won't find a spell effect from these actions except perhaps the occasional *thaumaturgy*.

Childbirth is celebrated by the entire Vassal community. This act of creation is usually associated with Arawai, and as such expecting Vassals will wear bracelets of woven wheat for the duration of their pregnancy. Once the child is born and healthy enough to go into public, a priest joins the parent(s) in conveying the infant to an altar, where a wheat offering is burned and then the priest uses the ashes to draw the octogram on the child's chest. Prayers at this moment are dedicated to the nine as a pantheon and then to each deity individually, asking them to guide the new community member throughout their life.

Marriage is an especially sacred sacrament to Vassals, as this is how Boldrei ties the community together. Scheduling a wedding requires consulting the Sovereign Book of Seasons, an alternate calendar that tracks the ever-shifting dates of both major and minor holidays dedicated to the various gods; it is best practice to schedule weddings for a minor holiday tied to Arawai, Boldrei, or at least Kol Korran. Boldrei's colors are orange and gray,

which is reflected in the traditional orange wedding dress. During the ceremony, couples exchange durable tokens that represent their pledge to each other; while these are often rings, some communities and couples prefer bracelets, necklaces, or other items that can be worn or carried at all times. While Vassals in other nations are often married in exciting weddings that are mostly big parties, Karnathi Vassals lead much more somber occasions, complete with ritualistic chanting that beseeches the Host for a blessing.

RELATIONSHIPS OUTSIDE OF MARRIAGE

The importance of marriage does not mean that Vassals condemn or shame romantic and/or sexual relationships if neither party is married; it is adultery that Vassals condemn. Breaking the covenant of marriage is the Fury's domain, a scandalous and deeply immoral action. Unfortunately, Vassal communities vary in their support of divorce; some exert significant pressure on partners who are nevertheless unhappy to stay together.

Polygamy and polyamory have gone in and out style; Kaius currently maintains a harem, whose semi-formal status means it is neither adultery nor true polygamy. The arduous inheritance requirements of the Kingdom of Galifar (five children, one for each province) mean it has never truly been shunned, but the amount of drama that comes from such a feudal inheritance system means it's rarely been replicated outside of the kingdom's capital.

Vassals believe that when they die and their soul passes into Dolurrrh, the process of fading is actually their soul being purified so it can ascend to the realm of the Sovereigns, beyond the reach of mortal magic. As such, funerals are for the loss felt by the living rather than a belief in death as a fundamental tragedy. Funerals involve a procession of the deceased's casket, led by a priest of the Host. Public offerings are made to the nine Sovereigns, but a more secret offering is made to the Keeper to placate his greed—Vassals are buried with gold and other valuables, so that the Keeper might take those instead of the soul of the deceased. Throughout Karnath's history, some particularly religious nobles have buried themselves with extravagant riches and protected their tombs with traps to deter would-be grave robbers.

The Sovereign Host has been the religion of Karnath's rulers for millenia, although King Galifar brought it into special focus by claiming the direct blessing of Aureon. Coronations are grand affairs, with sacrifices offered both by the crown and the people, in recognition that their combined goodwill is necessary for a prosperous rule. During the ceremony a priest raises the octogram immediately after placing the crown upon the new ruler's head, signifying that the gods of the Host still sit above the power of any mortal monarch while blessing the new ruler.

HOLIDAYS

The Sovereign Book of Seasons operates on a sixteen-day cycle, with each member of the Host and the Six having a day and the sixteenth reserved for the pantheon as a whole. While most Vassals in Khorvaire use the days dedicated to the Dark Six to consciously avoid associated activities and proactively reject their influence, many Karrns try to understand the lessons the Six offer. Karnathi Vassals use these days to engage with and

temper their vices, focusing more on changing their behavior than expecting forgiveness from others.

The Sovereign New Year (*1 Therendor [March]*) is unusual in that the congregation is expected to fully gather for an offering, honoring each member of the Host and asking for their blessing for the coming year.

Frostbreak (*3 Therendor [March]*) is a festival dedicated to Kol Korran, ringing in the new year with sales and new markets after the harsh winter. In rural Karnath this is an opportunity to showcase goods that were made while sheltering inside; for urban Karnns, it's also a day of pranks and games, honoring Kol Korran's trickster nature.

Fortunetide (*7 Therendor [March]*) is a gift-giving holiday dedicated to Olladra; while Karnns disfavor gambling, sharing in good fortune is something they understand. Many of the presents for this holiday are bought earlier in the week, during the Frostbreak markets. Especially in the northern half of Karnath, superstitions abound about which omens point to an early spring or extended winter.

Sun's Blessing (*15 Therendor [March]*) is a day of forgiveness and reconciliation in honor of Dol Arrah. Karnns take this holiday seriously; gifts are often exchanged between those who had conflict over the past year as symbols of moving past bad blood.

Aureon's Crown (*26 Dravago [May]*) is an important day for both students and nobles, as it's the traditional day for graduation ceremonies, accolades, and coronations. While Karnath is not as known for magical studies as Aundair, Rekkenmark is second to none as a school for the arts of war and always holds grandiose ceremonies on this holiday. When Kaius was crowned in 990, the school pushed its graduation back a day so students could attend the coronation in Korth then cram the lightning rail to return to Rekkenmark.

Brightblade (*12 Nymm [June]*) is an incredibly popular holiday within Karnath, as it's a holiday dedicated to the martial prowess of Dol Dorn. Local military commanders organize tournaments across a variety of martial disciplines; a youth's performance on Brightblade influences the quality of their position during their 2-year mandatory service.

The Hunt (*1 Barrakas [August]*) is a celebration of Balinor. An especially popular holiday in rural Karnath, Vassals of all ages cheer on or participate in competitive hunts. The goal is to bring back the most impressive game. In urban Karnath, the holiday is usually just an excuse to throw an animal-themed party, rather than any kind of actual hunt being involved.

Boldrei's Feast (*9 Rhaan [September]*) is a bright and cheery fall festival where the wealthy throw parties for the entire community. Unlike other nations, Karnath has no elections to conduct during Boldrei's Feast. The crown has placed great emphasis on this holiday since the end of the war in an attempt to highlight "the prosperity made possible through peace."

Wildnight (*18 Sypheros [October]*) is a party dedicated to the Fury. The level and tone of revelry varies from town to town, but it's always been a countercultural event popular more so with youth the disaffected than with temple regulars.

Ripeseed (*11 Aryth [November]*) is a harvest festival dedicated to Arawai. It's an opportunity for communities to give thanks for the bounty that will keep them from famine. Some communities also make offerings to the Devourer on the following day to keep them from the worst of the winter storms.

Long Shadows (*26–28 Vult [December]*) is a particularly frightening holiday in Karnath, as many communities are located near Mabaran manifest zones that grow in strength on these darkest nights of the year. Not only are the dark magics of mortals more potent, but supernatural forces find it much easier to slip into the material plane on these black nights.

Heartforge (*11 Zarantyr [January]*) is a day of competition in the name of Onatar. Celebrating both the forge and the fire that powers it, communities gather around the warmth of the smithy while those practiced in its arts work from dawn until dusk to create something new. The following day, the creations are judged and tested.

THREE FACES OF WAR

An ancient mystery cult dedicated to Dol Arrah, Dol Dorn, and Dol Azur (aka the Mockery), the Three Faces of War claims to have originated with Karn the Conqueror himself. Unlike most military fraternities, the Three Faces of War isn't just for officers; it's for any soldier who recognizes that war comes in many forms. Initiates receive three rings; a gold ring for Dol Arrah, a steel ring for Dol Dorn, and a leather ring for Dol Azur. Sometimes it's best to wear your gold ring during a prisoner exchange to show honor and respect, other times it's necessary to wear a leather ring during guerilla tactics when you do whatever is necessary to win. While it is still strongest in Karnath, this fraternal order spread throughout Galifar via the academy of Rekkenmark, as generations of officers throughout all the nations joined the cult during their education.

While most followers of the mystery cult consider themselves Vassals and otherwise engage in those practices, the cult itself has few rituals in common with traditional Vassal worship of these gods. External views vary; some consider them heretical, some view them through a conspiratorial lens, but most people in Khorvaire are only dimly aware of its existence and at most consider it an oddity.

DRAGO THUL, WARLORD IN EXILE

The exiled Karnnathi general Drago Thul (human he/him) was born a commoner. His religious devotion, martial skill, and tactical genius allowed him to advance through the ranks to the highest echelons of Karnath's military. His steadfast belief in Karnath's potential led him to oppose Kaius III's peace efforts, culminating in the 995 confrontation between the two as reported in the Korranberg Chronicle. Despite living in exile in Stormreach, he has maintained connections to Khorvaire through political and military allies that follow the Three Faces of War.

LIFE IN KARNNATH

The people of Karnnath live in a state of transition from the old world to the new; no longer the sword arm of an empire, they must contend with the post-treaty world order. Some prefer to preserve traditions like playing conqueror, a chess-like war game that is beloved across the nation. Others explore the future with speculative fiction, blending the known with the unknown in novels. Not all traditions are universal—regional variations are explored in chapter 6—but this chapter captures the overall state of the nation.

ART

Atur is the home of House Thuranni's True Shapers Enclave—which, for the duration of the Kingdom of Galifar's existence, was simply House Phiarlan's Demesne of Shape. Khorvaire's best sculptors, painters, architects, potters, and even costumers all learned their craft in Karnnath.

ARCHITECTURE

Prior to the outbreak of the war, the most popular architectural style in Karnnath was a neoclassical revival of the style during Karrn the Conqueror's rule. Relatively plain facades and the ornamental use of rows of columns define this style, especially in pre-war government or religious buildings.

Since Kaius I took the crown, Karnnathi royals have pushed for a new style that recognized the role Karnnath would play in the changing world. "Honest", plain brick constructions were far more economical than the solid stone of the neoclassical style. These newer buildings also take advantage of advances in metallurgy and glass by including many windows, whose shape are squared on three sides with a rounded top. The emphasis on form matching functionality makes it easy to differentiate between government buildings, factories, schools, and temples.

FASHION

Karnn fashion reflects both the nation's martial nature and its colder climate. In the rural countryside, thick woolen clothing is preferred, made not only from sheep's wool but also that of the mammoths that call the tundra of north-central Karnnath home. Urban dwellers prefer to emulate the dress uniforms of the military, with sharp lines and dark fabrics accentuated by metal. All Karnns appreciate the warmth and utility of a solid cloak.

Mandatory military service has made Karnns comfortable around arms and armor, but the strict Code of Kaius limits civilian access to weapons. The well-to-do may strut around in decorative armor, but the sword at their side will be peace-bound unless they have a governmental position that frees them from such burdens. During the Blood of Vol years, ivory accessories from Lyodnica were popular adornments on military uniforms (e.g. skull pauldrons), but over the last two decades there have been serious pushes to reclaim the "Galifaran" style with a more understated silhouette and materials. While Karnnath may lack the industrial capacity to cheaply and efficiently mass-produce arms and armor, Karnn smiths

take pride in each piece; elite creations are as renowned as those of the greatest clothing makers of Cyre or Thrane.

MUSIC AND THE PERFORMING ARTS

While Karnnath does not host the Demesnes of Memory, Motion, or Music, it has still developed its own rich tradition of musical theater. In Korth, opera music and performances are popular; most are mythological in subject matter, involving epic stories of the Sovereigns. By contrast, Karrlakton is the home of ballet, where House Deneith's leadership has historically enjoyed the precision and athleticism of the dancers. Karnnathi ballets often invoke stories of the fey, retelling the dangers of the Merchant of Misthaven or the adventures of Lady Perilous.

A recent innovation has combined performances with food options; the Korth opera houses and Karrlakton ballet companies have contracted with House Ghallanda to serve lunch and dinner. This has allowed them to provide all-day bundles of two shows along with their meals, a popular choice among Karnnath's emerging middle class.

Outside of the cities, rural folk music features dizzying songs performed upon the viol. State-sponsored traveling shows for soldiers near the front dramatically increased the popularity of both the Korth and Karrlakton performing groups, with many rural communities now setting up copycat shows based on the big-city hits.

VISUAL ARTS

The elvish style has always been to prefer illusionism—depicting things as realistically as possible, as if you were simply scrying on whatever was depicted. House Phiarlan was extremely successful in advancing this vision of the arts under the Kingdom of Galifar; within Karnnath, House Thuranni has maintained this tradition. Paintings of historical and mythological events are extremely detailed, with excruciating attention to exact depictions of not just the people but the supernatural creatures captured within.

CLIMATE

As one of Khorvaire's larger nations, Karnnath spans a diverse range of biomes, from the icy tundra along the Bitter Sea to the warm rolling hills that soften into the Talenta Plains. All these regions are shaped by the brutal storms that besiege the nation each winter, which only get worse when Risia is coterminous and global temps are 10°(F) colder.

The northern coast, despite its thin population, captures an outsized share of the Karnnathi imagination; brave captains forging their own way in unforgiving waters, while towns and villages endure upwards of eight months of snow each year. This region is defined by the permafrost that chokes out any trees, which softens in the summer months to a foot-deep bog. Life is largely dependent on the sea, enjoying the rich summer bounty then hibernating for the rest of the year. Some supernatural creatures reverse this trend, only venturing forth during the winter; for the people of the northern coast, this just reinforces the need to hunker down during the long dark months.

Further south are the boreal forests, the most famous of which is the region of the Karnnwood around Taer Syraen. While the average year-round temperature is above freezing here, the landscape remains harsh; heavy snowfall during the fall and early winter can make

traversal nearly impossible. Experienced travelers know to look for moonberries, a nutritious fruit that has adapted to use the light of Eberon's many moons for its growth and is most often found on cliff faces where it can see the sky. One lesser-known aspect of these forests is their dependence upon fire; every century or two, enormous fires surge through the forests to clear out the old growth and make way for the new. The last great fire was over one hundred and fifty years ago, and magical advancements in firefighting are still nowhere near capable of protecting the communities that have begun to make inroads into the forests.

The southern reaches of the Karnnwood, as well as the Shadowmount Forest, Nightwood, and Rekkenwood are temperate forests. These middle reaches are fairly humid and boast thick and productive soils, sometimes becoming swampy near rivers and streams in floodplains.

The open prairie of eastern and southern Karnnath is dryer than the rest of the nation, but nonetheless boasts rich soils well suited for growing crops. Wildfires are a yearly occurrence, creating tension between the strict controls of House Lyrandar and the holistic approach of the Talentan druids.

STORM SPIRES

Over the last century, increased access to dragonshards has allowed House Lyrandar to construct storm spires across the continent. These towering eldritch machines require active operation by a khoravar with the Greater Mark of Storm to recreate the effects of the *control weather* spell—an incredible work of magic when even fourth and fifth level spells are rare and expensive.

A storm spire's 100-mile range is significant; for context, the distance from Vedykar to Vulyar on the most popular Sivis-produced map is about 160 miles, meaning a storm spire halfway between the two could cover either city. Most storm spires are based in large cities with rail access and have an attached House Lyrandar enclave; the number of house heirs in the world who can operate one number in the low triple digits.

The spread of storm spires has allowed Karnnath to try and tame its long and harsh winters, but the consequences of the industrial use of weather magic are ill-studied. Consider the following impacts when describing Karnnath.

Is the weather dispersed or diverted? When the *control weather* power is invoked, it only covers an area with a 10-mile radius—far smaller than a natural cold front carrying rain and snow. If the spell effect *dispersed* the weather, then the question is just how fast can the spell work against the onslaught of a storm. If the spell *diverts* the weather, a storm spire is pushing the problematic winds and precipitation somewhere else—possibly inflicting extra damage on a rural community or endangering the natural habitat.

Is this bad for the natural cycle? The flora and fauna of a region are generally well-adapted to their natural climate. When natural cycles, such as the precipitation and winds of a winter storm, are disrupted it can have harmful long-term impacts on things that rely on those storms. Aquifers, especially downstream from mountains, often rely on winter storms to replenish; a dry winter could result in drought come summer. Easier winters can also be bad for plants, as more herbivores survive to chow down. Cults dedicated to the Three Faces of the Wild are especially

concerned with this impact; some may seek to study these changes scientifically, while others might take more direct action to stop the storm spires before it's too late.

How far is House Lyrandar willing to go? When a storm spire lies unused, that's lost profit for House Lyrandar. Most members are willing to accept the reality of the lost revenue, but some see it as a ransom opportunity. A particularly ruthless Lyrandar viceroy can suggest that if a storm spire is insufficiently used, it might "become unstable" and inflict damage.

Is Lamannia involved? Despite being referred to as the Twilight Forest, Lamannia encompasses the entire idea of the natural world. The dragons of Argonnessen discovered weather magic eons before House Lyrandar; has the conclave irrevocably altered the climate of Eberon, or does Lamannia balance this magic out over time? Alternatively, weather magic could have reverberations in the plane of nature, something the dragons have learned to account for, but House Lyrandar may be oblivious to or even willfully and dangerously brash about. If this is the case, will Lamannia empower druidic champions to stop the storm spires, or will they destabilize the planar balance first?

STORM SPIRE

Wondrous item, very rare (requires attunement by a creature with the Mark of Storm and capable of casting a fourth-level spell)

This eldritch machine is a dragonmark focus item. You gain the following benefits while you are attuned to a storm spire:

- While you are within 10 miles of the spire, you can sense weather patterns within a 100-mile radius of the spire and accurately predict the weather for up to 24 hours.
- While you are within 60 feet of the spire, you can use an action to cast any of the following spells: *call lightning*, *fog cloud*, *gust of wind* at-will. You cast these as 5th level spells, and Intelligence is your spellcasting ability.
- While you are within 5 feet of the spire, you can cast *control weather* as a ten-minute ritual. This allows you to pick a point within 100 miles of the spire and influence the weather within a 10-mile radius of that point. Maintaining this effect requires concentration. Up to two additional creatures that meet the attunement requirements can join in the ritual, using their concentration. A second creature expands the radius to fifteen miles, while a third expands the radius to twenty.
- While you are within 5 feet of the spire, you can also use an action to influence weather within a ten-mile radius of the spire itself; you don't have to use concentration to maintain this effect, and you can sustain this while you're manipulating distant weather.

ECONOMY

The least industrialized of the four surviving nations, Karnnath's economy largely runs on extracting resources owned by its nobility. Logging, mining, and agriculture form the backbone of Karnnath's economy, but the production of paper and glass by craftsfolk along the southwestern river borders have diversified the nation's exports.

The vast forests Karnnathi loggers harvest provide ample material for all sorts of uses, from construction to paper. One critical barrier to expanding these operations is

the presence of fey and other supernatural threats seeking to preserve their forested territory.

Advancements in paper production during the 9th century were critical to mass literacy, the expansion of the *Korranberg Chronicle*, and even the accessibility of wizardry, reduced the cost of not just conventional printing but spellbook production. During the Last War, the Karnathi government commissioned an enormous number of propaganda posters; these were well received, and many Karnns today have taken them as souvenirs for their homes.

The mines of Karnnath are a productive useful asset to any noble whose land happens to include them. While the Ashen Spires and Icetop Mountains get plenty of attention for their mineral resources, many other locations throughout the nation harbor deposits of both precious and practical metals. One important difference from the real world is the lack of coal; Khorvaire lacks natural deposits of the easy-burning material, forcing the people to explore alternative means of building larger & better forges such as magical enchantments and bound elementals. This reliance on artifice for mundane steel production has cemented Cannith's central role in Khorvaire's economy.

Karnnath is also known for its glass production; the material for this primarily comes from the beaches along the Cyre River, where the sand has the right purities and properties to be made into glass. While House Cannith produces the tools glassblowers use, each piece of glass is still handmade; there are no arcane forges to produce windowpanes or jars en masse. Magic is a part of the process, but in an individualized fashion—magewrights use magic to create shapes and colors that mundane techniques could not produce.

FOOD

One perplexing riddle for Karnnath is that despite its climate being favorable for agriculture, the nation faced numerous famines throughout the Last War. The explanation favored by the crown has been that before the intervention of Lady Illmarrow, the nation had no issues—treacherous Seekers and agents of the Order of the Emerald Claw held the nation's food supply as a hostage, inflicting famines as punishment for when the nation's rulers wouldn't bow to the lich queen's demands. The truth is almost certainly more complicated; the famine of 996, just two short years ago, does not appear to have been caused by plagued grain or any other attack and was instead caused by an early winter and governmental mismanagement. Hoarding by warlords and counts has certainly contributed to the nation's problems throughout the Last War, amplifying food insecurity created by the periodic treacherous actions of Lady Illmarrow's followers.

Karnnath's meat and dairy industry has greatly enjoyed the resumed international trade, buoyed by advances in preservation magic developed by House Ghallanda. Magebred cattle introduced less than a decade before the start of the Last War are not only capable of producing *more* milk but can produce *unusual* milk; imported chocolate from Xen'drik has been used to create brown cows that naturally produce chocolate milk. These milks allow for even more inventive cheese production, much of which is still in its infancy due to the long time frames. Meat production is even more varied, with different

regions favoring different animals—but all are enjoyed across the continent.

Karnnathi breweries are also popular abroad, their most famous product being Nightwood Ale. The drink's thick, full flavor and dark, robust body result from the complicated influence of Mabaran manifest zones. International shipments are often guarded by Deneith mercenaries due to long-standing agreements between the sentinels of Karrlakton and nearby brewers.

DRAGONMARKED HOUSES

The Twelve, the international consortium of the dragonmarked houses, is headquartered in Korth. While it's not answerable to the Karnnathi crown like the Arcane Congress is to the Aundairian crown, it's still an incredibly valuable resource and institution within the nation. Throughout the Last War, Karnnathi scholars could provide the intellectual muscle that the Twelve were sometimes cut off from due to travel restrictions, strengthening the bond between the Twelve and its host nation.

House Jorasco is based in the city of Vedykar. These healing halflings provide services throughout Khorvaire, but the repeated plagues that Karnnath suffered in the last century drew the house's attention close to home. There are also persistent rumors that the house cooperated with both the state and the Blood of Vol to research and weaponize diseases, but these rumors are unflinchingly denied by the house's leader, Baron Uladra.

The nation's most iconic house is Deneith, which calls Karrlakton its home. The Mark of Sentinel has held sway in Karnnath since even before Karnn's time. Each of the house's families originate from different duchies, and to this day they maintain unique chimera heraldry representing different combinations of dragons and beasts. Under the Kingdom of Galifar, the house brokered Karnnathi soldiers to fulfill enlistment quotas; by the end of Jarot's reign, enlistment requirements had grown so high the house turned south to the Darguul goblinoids to meet these quotas. The secessions of Darguun and Valenar in the middle of the century chastened the house, which



now continues to recruit from across Khorvaire but especially in Karnath, where mandatory military service has created a large pool of recruits.

The nation's capital, Korth, is home to Cannith East under the direction of Zorlan d'Cannith. While House Cannith has always had operations in Karrnath, Zorlan carefully curried favor with King Jaron after arriving with the first of the warforged in 966. When Regent Moranna abolished the state's connection to the Blood of Vol in 976, she was surprised to find that Zorlan had genuinely and sincerely adopted the faith, a faith which he carries forward to today. Cannith East finds itself in a strange position, both prodding Karrnath along on its path to industrialization while Zorlan spearheads secretive weapons research that blends Karnathi necromancy with traditional artifice techniques.

Eastern Khorvaire, which of the original five nations only includes Karrnath, is the domain of House Thuranni. Before the Shadow Schism, Karnathi nobles relied heavily on the Serpentine Table of House Phiarlan to provide intelligence; House Thuranni's reach is far shorter, a limitation that pushed Moranna to create the Dark Cabinet, a new national intelligence agency. Instead, House Thuranni fulfills a different role—its assassins have fully replaced the Order of the Emerald Claw when the crown engages in wetworks operations; alleged ties between the two organizations don't seem to be a major concern of the crown. Beyond their covert actions, the Thurannis are deeply embedded in the Karnathi art scene, as detailed previously.

LAW AND ORDER

Karnath is governed by the Code of Kaius, a far harsher and more authoritarian variation of the Code of Galifar. Martial law places near-absolute power in the hands of local commanders; Karnathi citizens accused of crimes do not have the benefit of a jury or an independent judiciary like their peers in Aundair or Breland. Since the end of the war, most of the nation has lifted its curfews and other strict restrictions on the freedom of movement, but not every count has fully transitioned away from wartime law.



MANDATORY SERVICE

All Karnathi citizens are required to serve in the nation's military for a minimum of two years, a tradition started by Karrn the Conqueror. Serving does not only include frontline positions; logistics are just as critical, especially during lean times. Sailors in Karrnath's navy often served dual purposes, transporting material as well as engaging Aundairian or Lhazaarite forces in the Bitter Sea. During some periods of the war, mandatory deployment commitments were extended, in some cases up to 8 years. Deployments tend to keep people from a town or village together, a strategy that has left some towns completely depleted of a generation due to disastrous battles.

While humans, dwarves, elves, and other peoples have very different average life spans, they each have entered physical maturity by the age of 18, at which point they are legally adults and required to enter service. Deferments are rare but possible; military service has long been a point of pride and a critical shared experience to Karrns. Dodging service is a point of deep shame and dishonor. Many Karrns chose to spin their mandatory service into full careers, spending over a decade in the military before either coming home or joining the House Deneith Blademark's Guild.

THE MINISTRY OF THE DEAD

Perhaps no group within the Karnathi government is more sensationalized by the foreign press than the royal corpse collectors, founded in 896 as part of Kaius I's embrace of necromancy. The simple truth is the nation lacks the resources to convert the bodies of ordinary citizens into undead soldiers—battlefield recoveries have usually proved sufficient. This is not to say it never happened, but the typical job of the royal corpse collectors was to recover the remains of the nation's *elite* soldiers, to be transformed by the Odakyr Rites into the elite Karnathi Undead. Once a body is collected, other agencies within the ministry manage inventory, perform necromantic rituals, and conduct research. Today, the royal corpse collectors sift through the nation's morgues for suitable subjects, far pickier than when they needed to supply entire legions.

The leader of the Ministry of the Dead is Count Vedim ir'Omik. His lands at the edge of the Nightwood, halfway between Atur and Korth along the Karrn river, serve as a convenient place from which to coordinate the Ministry of the Dead. He's Moranna's second child, and during the war he enjoyed the perks of a high-ranking position. Since the Treaty of Thronehold, the Ministry of the Dead has lost much of the prestige and attention formerly accorded to it.

Despite Kaius III reducing the resources allocated to the agency, Vedim has continued research into the arcane science of necromancy. While Vedim may prove a useful lackey for more sinister elements, his primary motivation is preparing for what he sees as an inevitable Next War. What Kaius doesn't know is that Vedim is covertly experimenting with self-propagating undead, deploying squads of them within Valenar; the Count has been careful, but continued actions may spark an international incident.

WITHIN AND WITHOUT

Beyond the generalities of what it means to be Karnathi, distinct groups have their own history and relationship with the nation.

PEOPLES

Karnath has seen much less urbanization and industrialization than the nations of Western Khorvaire. Historic settlements along Karnath's protected interior waterways have always held the bulk of the nation's population but concerns about the Mournland—easily visible across the Cyre River which defines Karnath's southwestern border—led the crown to support resettlement programs along the Karnwood's edge and the northern coast.

HUMANS

Humanity makes up a little more than half of the citizenry of modern Karnath. Where the other races are more geographically concentrated—halflings to the south, elves in the urban west, dwarves in the east—humans are widely dispersed throughout the entire nation.

Religiously speaking, humans brought worship of the Sovereign Host with them from Sarlona. As faith traditions mixed and blended in the migration from the east, the peoples who settled Karnath adopted the full breadth of the Host but with an emphasis on its most martial deities. Some of these traditions have a long history, dating back to the ancient Sarlonan empire of Nulakesh, but this history is little known outside of academic circles. Faith in the Blood of Vol surged during the war while it was the state religion, but these days most people identify as Vassals.

DWARVES

The most numerous demographic in Karnath after humans at nearly a fifth of the total population, the dwarves of Khorvaire have long predated humanity. Originating in the Mror Holds, the dwarves naturally spread both west and east across the mountains. Those who had traveled east were the first people of Khorvaire to encounter humans as they came over the Lhazaar Sea. Some joined peaceably with the humans and their fleets, establishing the mixed towns of mainland Lhazaar; others were in conflict, such as the ancient predecessors of the modern Cloudreavers. Settlements such as Korth had dwarven members from the beginning, well before proper contact between humanity and the clans of the Mror Holds.

The second source of dwarves in Karnath is from the Mroran clan's westward expansion after the fall of the Dhakaani. While there is archaeological evidence of dwarven presence dating back to the early days of the Dhakaani Empire, by its height the goblinoids had completely pushed the dwarves back into the Ironroot Mountains. However, the fall of the Dhakaani Empire allowed the dwarves to move to the western plains and forests. These dwarves were not unified under any great empire and were easily conquered when Karrn expanded eastward in -1000 YK.

The biggest expansion of Karnath's dwarven population came under Galifar's son, Prince Karrn. Prince

Karrn emulated his father, using a mix of diplomatic intrigue and military force to subjugate the Mroran clans and extract tribute and taxes. The formal integration of the Mror Holds into the Kingdom of Galifar paved the way for dwarves to settle in Karnath, especially after House Kundarak joined the Twelve in 106 YK.

The dwarves of Karnath are typically devout Vassals, feeling comfort in the durable institution of the Sovereign Host as they see generations of humans come and go. Dwarves' innate affinity for stone has kept them close to the architectural and mining businesses, two strong interests of Karnath's warlords. While dwarves are underrepresented among Karnath's nobility compared to their population, titled dwarves are generally known to be formidable in both politics and war.

ELVES

In -1650 YK, less than a century after the appearance of the Mark of Sentinel, the Undying Court allied with the dragons of Argonessen to exterminate the elven line of Vol, known for their Mabaran necromancy and possession of the Mark of Death. Many of the dead house's allies fled, alongside those who were simply deeply uncomfortable with the raw display of power.

Some of those who ventured to Khorvaire bonded with the people of Karnath, spreading stories of a family that sought to conquer death itself but was struck down by jealous divinity. Some humans, embittered by their experience of the Host, mixed these stories with local superstitions about the nation's manifest zones. These new cults stumbled upon a new source of power—the Divinity Within, the foundation of the Blood of Vol. The elves of Karnath have always been associated with the faith, their long lives allowing them to maintain its traditions even without the martyrdom of undeath.

Despite the general association between elves and the Blood of Vol within Karnath, a notable exception exists within Korth. The elves of Aerenal have always detested Karnath's use of undead, but seem to have found a favorable ear with King Kaius III, to the point that one of their diplomats, Etrigani, won not just the ear of the young prince but his heart as well. The increased presence of Aereni elves within the city has raised tensions, as on a number of occasions Aereni nationals have openly committed property crimes by destroying laboring skeletons or zombies.

HALFLINGS

Primarily found in southern Karnath, halflings integrated with human settlements long before Karrn's bloody rampage. The height of this integration is localized in Vedykar, the home of House Jorasco. Relations between Karnathi and Talentan halflings are diverse; for some, there's a mutual respect and recognition. Others have no tolerance for the "backwards" nomadic life of Talenta or the "soft," sedentary life of Karnath. Either way, there's commerce and intermingling on the long Karnathi border.

Halflings tend to be drawn to the Sovereign Host over the Blood of Vol; many communities on the Talentan border freely intermix the gods of the Host with the spiritual traditions of the plains. By contrast, the Blood of Vol's total rejection of divinity is anathema to halfling cultural values that recognize the power of luck and destiny.

KHORAVAR

Millenia of elves living alongside humans in Karnath naturally led to descendants of mixed heritage. While the elves of Karnath have long been associated with the Blood of Vol, it was the khoravar who were instrumental in the faith's spread and development. While the original elven exiles brought an understanding of the power of Mabara and a certain nihilistic outlook on life, it was the khoravar who turned that into a focus on building networks of mutual aid within communities. Elven mysticism was transformed into a religion through the hard work of khoravar organizers, creating a critical difference between Mabaran practices in Karnath and those of the reclusive elves of Farlnen.

In the modern day, a recurring question for Karnathi khoravar at their unity dinners is what to do about Valenar. The continued military engagements between their home country and the elven warbands make House Lyrandar's promise of a new khoravar homeland questionable; the long lives of khoravar are a natural advantage within Karnath, so there's little desire among them to leave their current holdings. At the same time, the continued dominance of the top levels of Karnath's government by humans has some families questioning whether they would find a better life in the south, regardless of the border tensions. Kaius III's marriage to Etrigani is in many ways symbolic of the tension; if she were to bear an heir to the throne, that would cement khoravar support and acceptance. Conversely, Kaius' continued use of harems and the likelihood of another human heir to the throne might be enough to push Karnath's khoravar to emigrate to Valenar.

WARFORGED

Out of the entirety of the Five Nations, Karnath provides its people the fewest rights, with most of them having been pushed back into indentured servitude after the signing of the Treaty of Thronehold. The continuation of martial law in Karnath has laid hollow the promises of freedom in 996, with warforged barely having better status than skeletons raised by the Odakyr rites. This is not to say all warforged are treated poorly; servants of the state who perform their duties are well respected by the citizenry, but those who fail to conform to Karnathi expectations are expendable at best and seditious at worst.

GOBLINOIDS

Modern Karnath was always a frontier for the Dhakaani Empire, which ruled from southern Khorvaire. Evidence of the conflicts between goblins and fey or dwarves can still be found buried in ancient ruins that dot the Karnathi landscape. After the fall of the Dhakaani Empire, the goblin kingdoms that remained were far less grand in scope.

When humans arrived several thousand years ago, they were able to successfully push these goblins south and east, pinching them between the halflings of the plains and the dwarves of the mountains. After Karn took the throne and united Karnath's many kingdoms, he also launched a bloody war of extermination against the goblin kingdoms that still existed. This was largely successful, and even today Karnath has the smallest goblin population in the five nations. Even when House Deneith began to formally recruit goblins, just before the outbreak

of the Last War, few Karnathi warlords hired their services; this trend persisted throughout the war, in part due to the logistical difficulty of exporting Darguul mercenaries to the northern battlefields.

As the Kech Dhakaan have explored the surface world the last few decades, two have taken special notice of Karnath. The first is the Kech Nasaar, who are interested in learning from and adapting Karnathi necromantic techniques; while an exchange of equals would be possible, the Kech Nasaar are far more interested in acquiring state secrets through espionage. The second is the Kech Hashraac, whose hidden domain in Khyber has tunnels that lead to the Ashen Spires in Karnath's Duchy of Atur. While the Kech Hashraac are far less curious about the surface world than Kech Nasaar, the unique talents their Keepers of Thunder in the realm of warfare would be of interest to both Karnathi warlords and Cannith East.

GOLIATHS

Local to the northeastern Karnathi duchy of Lyodnica, the goliaths of the Mamont Tundra and Icetop Mountains are of unknown origin. Innately adapted to frigid environments, the various goliath groups have long preferred isolation to trying to integrate with the latest empire that brushes up against their inhospitable territory. The latest attempts by Karnath to settle and extract resources from the region may permanently disrupt the culture and lifestyle of these groups.

ORCS

Few orcs live within the modern borders of Karnath, as between the aggression of the Mroran Clans and the genocides perpetrated by Karnath no tribes remain west of the Ironroot mountains. However, the advent of House Tharashk several centuries ago brought Finders Guild mercenaries into Karnath, where they've garnered a reputation of reliability among the ruling elites.

PLANETOUCHE

Like the rest of Eberron, Karnath has a small population of planetouched; people whose ancestry has been modified by exposure to one of the thirteen planes. Whether these people are aasimar, tieflings, or some other mechanical representation is less relevant than the plane that has changed them. Generally speaking, planetouched are considered to be *omens* in Karnath; not inherently bad or good, but important nonetheless.

The most common form of planetouched in Karnath are people who have been shaped by one of the nation's many Mabaran manifest zones. Despite the plane's association with the undead, Mabaran planetouched are often supernaturally beautiful. Rather than being feared, Mabaran planetouched are seen as protectors, gifted with the ability to withstand the harmful effects of manifest zones. Despite this, few are religious, shunning both the community-oriented Blood of Vol and the idea that their gifts are the blessings of the Sovereigns.

Another form of planetouched is a heritage tied to Thelanis, which is especially common in proximity to Taer Syraen. Unlike most of the residents of other planes, fey are capable of directly having children with mortals and these descendants constitute a notable portion of Thelanian planetouched. Attitudes towards Thelanian

planetouched vary dramatically; the fey of Karnath are hostile and dangerous, and more than one hexblood has been blamed for actions that were not theirs.

While most of Karnath's climate is driven by storms coming from the Bitter Sea, the nation does have several Risian manifest zones. Cool and collected, Risian planetouched are known for taking the long view and are valued in the halls of government.

Records are unclear whether the Shavaran manifest zones in southwestern Karnath were created by or were the cause of the region's history of conflict. Either way, the planetouched of Shavarath appear in Karnath's history as both heroes and villains and are expected to take up arms in the service of their lord—or, in a few cases, become warlords themselves.

There are only a few Daanvi manifest zones in Karnath, but Daan planetouched are held as holy figures by Karnathi Vassals. This belief traces back to the nation's roots in the ancient Sarlonan nation of Nulakesh, where Daan manifest zones were far more common and the planetouched of Daanvi were core to the nation's government.

While manifest zones to other planes can be found in Karnath, they're less generally influential than the five mentioned here and there's no specific cultural assumptions about the nature of planetouched of those planes. *Tiefling Treatise* provides a general overview of planetouched tieflings and has inspiration for both aesthetic and personality traits.

UNDEAD

The Code of Kaius that governs Karnath does not accord any more rights to undead than the Code of Galifar that governs the rest of the continent; undead are still considered property of a person or institution. For mindless undead, such as skeletons and zombies, this is a simple enough matter—they are the property of whomever raised them unless they have been formally transferred. For sapient undead, such as vampires or liches, matters are trickier; while the Karnathi state is certainly more tolerant than other nations of their existence, a vampire nonetheless has no more rights than a fancy piano. Destruction of property is still absolutely a crime, and under martial law penalties can be quite harsh, but it's not eligible for capital punishment. As such, sapient undead are typically attached to institutions or persons who have the resources to both support them and provide some level of protection from errant do-gooders. The diminishment of the Blood of Vol has left some undead stranded without legal protection, forcing them to choose between giving into their predatory nature or eking out an existence on the edge of a society that has discarded them.

CHANGELINGS

In the centuries between Karnn uniting the nation under one banner and Galifar uniting the continent, a widespread paranoia about cults of the Traveler and changelings spilled forth from the churches of Daskaran. The nobles of Korth, like the nobles of Daskara and Metrol, were taken by this panic and began a bloody inquisition. Many Karnathi changelings fled west to Thaliost and south to the halfling-dominated plains, starting up new lives in more tolerant lands. This purge burned itself out after a few decades, but the demographic shift remained; Karnath

has among the lowest changeling populations in the continent.

Changelings in Karnath today must contend with the harshness of martial law; the wide-ranging powers granted to authorities combined with extremely reduced civil liberties means that even an ordinary misunderstanding could quickly turn dangerous for the accused. Karns, as a principle, also have little tolerance for the games and humor that innate shapeshifting can provide—Karnathi changelings tend to have one form they prefer and stick to it.

KALASHTAR

Karnath's kalashtar population is largely limited to the Temple Ward of the city of Korth these days, as the sacking of Narath destroyed the only other significant kalashtar community within the nation. The kalashtar of Karnath are content to keep to themselves, sequestered away from the war with the quori that defines so many of their people. Outsiders are considered more likely to be threats than allies; the best way to stay safe is to let nobody in.

FOREIGN RELATIONS

The people of Karnath have been naturally isolated from the rest of Khorvaire since the destruction of Cyre; the destruction of the White Arch Bridge linking Rekkenmark to Thaliost at the start of the war cut off land routes from Aundair, while the creation of the Mournland destroyed the remaining lightning rail lines connecting eastern and western Khorvaire.

AERENAL

By any measure, Aereni diplomacy to Karnath has been astoundingly effective over the past three decades; the crown has publicly rejected the influence of Lady Illmarrow, the king married a diplomat, and the nation has significantly drawn down its use of Mabaran undead. While trade opportunities are sometimes limited—requiring passage north and south through the Lhazaar Principalities—Kaius has established magical means of direct communication with the Sibling Kings. The extent of Kaius's relationship is unknown except to his closest confidants, both in terms of how much the Aereni know and what future plans the two parties have in their campaign against Lady Illmarrow.

AUNDAIR

At odds since the start of the war, Karnath and Aundair have fought many battles on land and in the Bitter Sea. Furthermore, their two monarchs could not be more sharply contrasting; Aurala truly believes that she can unite the continent through a just war, while Kaius is a cruel and brutal man who fought hard for the peace of Thronehold. Despite this, the two nations have fairly good diplomatic relations, and trade relations between them are fully open. Some of this can be attributed to the two being the nations that have most closely maintained Galifar's feudal structures, allowing for a much easier resumption of pre-war openness. Still, disputes over Bitter Sea fishing rights remain a live issue for future diplomatic summits.

BRELAND

Karnathi soldiers almost never came into contact with the Brelish. Even when the two nations were opposed due to their alliances, the sheer geographic distance between them diluted any significant animosity. Diplomatically, however, Kaius sees Breland as a direct threat; while Boranel may be content to hibernate, the raw strength of Breland's industry concerns him for when new leadership takes over. The distance between the two limits trade opportunities—neither Wroat nor Sharn are directly accessible from the riverways of Scions Sound, dramatically extending the time it takes for Karnathi goods to reach the people of these two cities.

CYRE

In the immediate aftermath of the disaster of 994, Karnath treated the Cyran refugees as prisoners of war, keeping them in camps until a political solution was found. When the treaty was under negotiation, Kaius was warmly supportive of resettlement efforts so long as they weren't inside Karnath. Despite the strategic resettlement efforts within Karnath to establish new settlements in the northern duchies, Kaius was unwilling to take the Cyrans in, largely due to distrusting the people of a nation his country had made war against for the majority of the century. He is currently evaluating whether a gift of further resources might buy Oargev's allyship and enable New Cyre to declare independence, weakening Breland and gaining Karnath a regional ally.

DROAAM

While the Treaty of Thronehold did not recognize the Daughters of Sora Kell and their nation, Kaius sees opportunities in all the problems these distant monsters can create for their neighbors. Unfortunately, House Deneith is not fond of the competition that House Tharashk has created through its monstrous mercenary force, the Dragonne's Roar. Droaam is too far away to think about for the general citizenry of Karnath, although they have a general disinclination to like the nation's residents. Kaius is privately concerned about Sora Teraza and what visions she might have seen about his future and his past.

ELDEEN REACHES

The bounty of the Eldeen Reaches has been critical in supporting Karnath through its famines. After the Reaches seceded from Aundair, Karnathi warships spent the latter half of the war protecting food shipments across the Bitter Sea, while in return providing arms to fuel the Eldeen secession effort. Today, the people of the Reaches are more interested in fine goods such as Karnathi glass than arms, although both Karnath and the Eldeen Reaches carefully watch for signs of Aundairian aggression.

LHAZAAR PRINCIPALITIES

Prior to the Last War, the Lhazaar Principalities had been technically under Karnathi governance since the end of the Galifar-Lhazaar war of the first century YK. As soon as the Last War broke out, the principalities fractured and alliances began being made with individual princes. Prince

Shaen Tasil of the Bloodsail Principality was an early and solid ally of Karnath, acting under orders from Lady Illmarrow to ensure dominance in the Bitter Sea. After Moranna denounced Lady Illmarrow in 976 YK the Bloodsails turned on Karnath, contesting trade and travel through those northeastern channels that connect the Bitter Sea to the Lhazaar Sea. This break has made other Lhazaar princes more willing to deal with Karnath, many of whom now profit immensely from warm relations with Kaius and the various warlords.

MROR HOLDS

Since their secession, relations with the Iron Council have ranged from icy to bloody. Much to the crown's chagrin, Karnath must *trade* with the Mror rather than simply extracting tribute. Two truths define the country's relationship – the first is that geographic proximity and pre-existing infrastructure make the two natural economic partners. The second is that Karnath's repeated attempts to annex the Mror Holds have hardened the hearts of the majority-dwarven nation.

Q'BARRA

While technically Karnathi land before the war, Q'barra was ignored during the Galifaran era. Today, King Sebastes is seen as a pitiable figure in the courts of Karnath, an upstart noble who thinks that owning land is all it takes to be a proper king. The resources of the land are certainly intriguing, but New Galifar is a lesser state that most Karnathi believe will eventually be subsumed when Karnath once again rises to glory.

RIEDRA

During the Karnathi famines of the Last War, the empire of Riedra extended a helping hand on extremely generous terms, becoming a key source of food. Today, Kaius is wary of the Riedrans but far more concerned with the politics of Khorvaire; he is unaware of the Dreaming Dark's capabilities and their connection to the Inspired rulers of Riedra.

TALENTA PLAINS

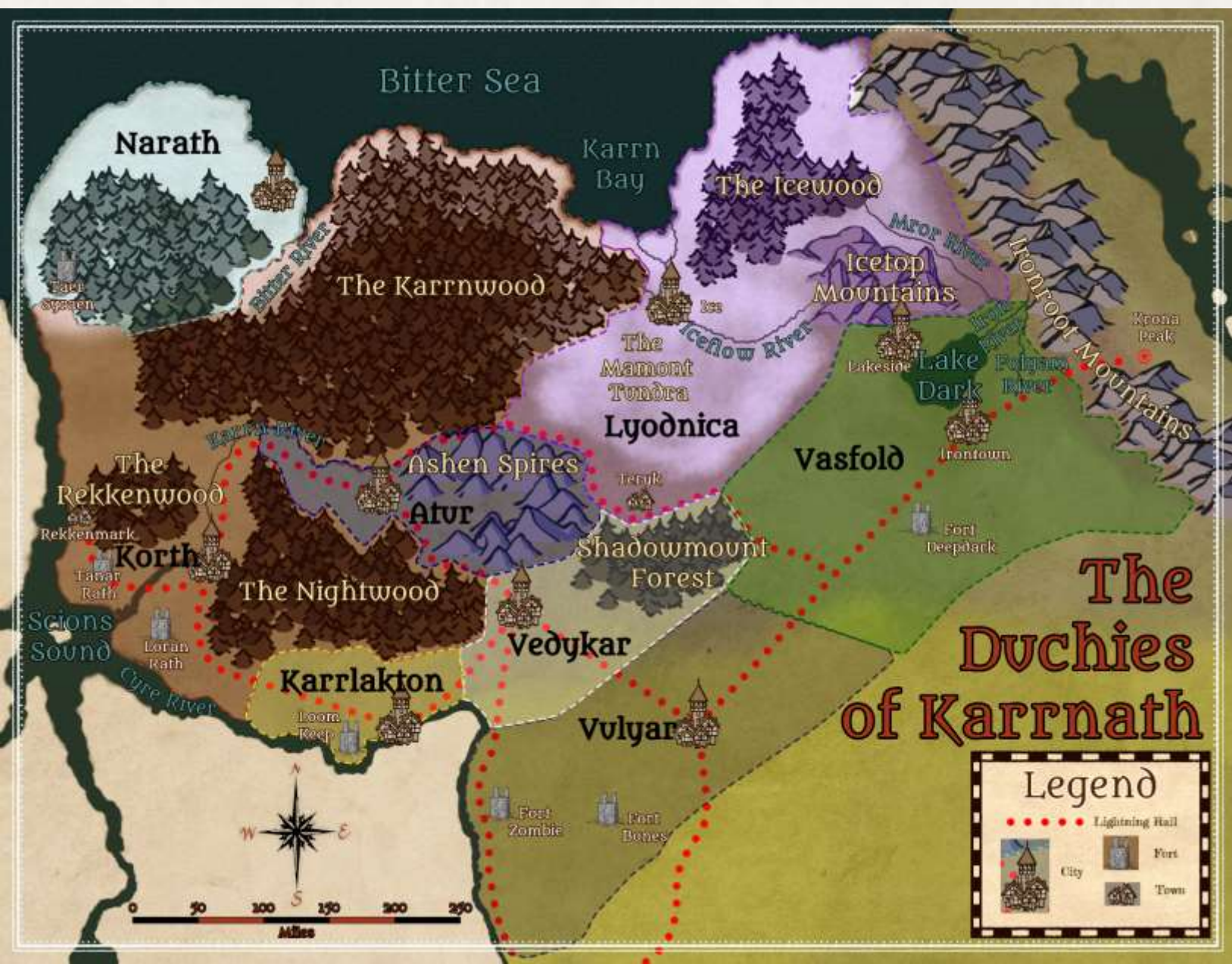
Under the Kingdom of Galifar, the Talenta Plains were part of Karnath and largely ignored. The halfling tribes paid tribute but never found it so burdensome as to seriously consider rebellion and independence. When the war broke out, some tribes allied themselves with Karnath while others joined up with Cyre; even more warriors separately signed onto House Deneith mercenary recruiting outfits. After decades of bloodshed, the halflings joined together and declared independence, breaking away from Karnath. The Talenta Plains were formally recognized in the Treaty of Thronehold. Today, the Talenta Plains are the battleground for Karnath's simmering war with the elves of Valenar; the government of Karnath, from monarch to reeve, hopes to recruit the halflings to their cause and provide a stronger buffer against Valenar raids than that which currently exists.

THRANE

The intense opposition between Thrane and Karnath made their mutual agreement to come to peace talks all the more surprising. Although the two started the war as allies, Thrane immediately broke off the agreement two years later when Karnath embraced the Blood of Vol and began to use undead. The aerial assaults of Rekkenmark and Korth by Thrane and the destruction of Shadukar by Karnath only furthered the bad blood. While Karnath doesn't share a border with Thrane, the two often engaged in pitched naval battles in Scions Sound. Kaius, the staunch monarchist, distrusts the Council of Cardinals and would much rather see Diani elevated to the power and prestige due a proper monarch.

VALENAR

Karnath's primary antagonists at the present are the elves of Valenar, who continue to conduct raids against the southern duchies in violation of the Treaty of Thronehold. High King Shaeras Vadallia hosts and entertains Karnathi diplomats, denying any connection to the "rogue clans" who attack Karnathi soldiers. Courtesy of Etrigani, Kaius understands that the High King is trying to bait him into war, and so he's ordered his southern warlords to keep their forces on a tight leash.



DUCHIES

Karnath is divided into eight duchies of varying areas and populations. While they all share the characteristics described previously for Karnath as a whole, the nation's size has fostered the growth of regional distinctions and subcultures.

In theory, Karnath's government is structured as a pyramid—King Kaius III sits at the top as ruler of the nation. Each Warlord rules a duchy and owes direct fealty to the king. Duchies are divided into counties which are ruled by counts and countesses, and then counties are divided into reeves which are administered by crown reeves. Realistically, the warlords vary in their fealty to Kaius; while they fulfill their obligations of raising troops for the crown, they use all other forms of support as leverage to achieve their own political ends. The combined actions of Moranna and Kaius over the last half century have destabilized Karnath's political landscape, with more than one warlord seeing the throne as within reach if they navigate the conqueror board just right.

ATUR

The only grand duchy in Karnath, Atur was an independent bastion of the Blood of Vol long before Kaius I turned to the faith. Although small, the duchy enjoys the rich onyx mines of the Ashen Spires which—in conjunction with the Mabaran manifest zone that blankets the city—have long fueled the necromantic magic Atur is known for. The duchy's southern and western borders end at the edge of the Nightwood. Despite the Nightwood's connection to Mabar matching Atur's specialties, Atur long ago conceded the spooky forest to Korth.



HISTORY

Little is known of Atur's history during the Age of Monsters; archaeological evidence from that era is simply missing, a gap that most scholars attribute to the area's Mabaran influence. When humans expanded east from Korth, they found a large, barren plain shrouded in eternal mist. The region was a font of undead monsters and became known as the "Lake of Shadows." Recognizing the influence of the Eternal Night, the human colonizers avoided the area and settled elsewhere.

It wasn't until the elves arrived from Aerenal, exiled for their alliance with the line of Vol, that Atur could be settled. Human industriousness met elven magic, channeling the energies of the manifest zone into structured necromantic magic and allowing this otherwise-desirable location to blossom under the leadership of the necromancer Duran (human he/him). Many Phiarlans chose to settle in Atur as well, comfortable in a new kingdom with strong elven representation.

Atur's first major challenge came with the rise of Karnn, five centuries after its founding. While Karnn's armies were mighty, the potent power of the city's harnessed Mabaran manifest zone made an assault against it costly. Furthermore, any attempt to bring the city's rulers and their grim faith to heel would render the area uninhabitable once more. Negotiations led to Atur's designation as Karnath's one and only Grand Duchy, a free bastion that would meet the crown's troop obligations but was otherwise independent.

The coming of Galifar did little to change Atur's independence, although the expanded reach of the kingdom allowed for sensational stories to spread. Tales of midnight debauchery, skeletal servants, and all sorts of other ideas spread throughout the Five Nations, earning the city a reputation as an amoral abyss. "What happens in Atur, stays in Atur" captures both the festive nature of the city and its cloying darkness and embrace of undeath.

The onset of the Last War and Kaius I's embrace of the Blood of Vol transformed the city from a culturally unique bastion of independence to the most important city in the nation. Necromancy—which had been a longtime specialty of the city but generally reviled by the nation's Vassal majority—became Karnath's most important asset of the war. Atur Academy, once a small educational institution, began churning out state necromancers to fill the arcane needs for more reanimated soldiers. While battlefield necromancy could help, it was the rituals developed with the help of the Mabaran manifest zone in Atur that could produce an army. Lightning rail cars full of coffins traveled to Atur, returning with standing-room-only legions of skeletons for the frontlines; and the lightning rail between Korth and Atur was expanded and improved to match the needs of the nation.

The end of the Blood of Vol's status as the state religion in 976 did not end Karnath's need for reanimated soldiers to fill its ranks. While the state ended its direct funding for religious institutions like the Crimson Monastery and the integration of Blood of Vol clerics with regular military units, the necromantic functions of Atur Academy and the Ministry of the Dead continued.

Atur mostly avoided the ravages of war, but its fortunes shifted at the tail end of the conflict. In late 993, a Cyran army backed by the newly constructed WX-31 Colossus invaded Karnath, taking an eastern route around

Karrlakton, hugging the edge of the Nightwood, and largely bypassing Vedykar en route to Atur. WX-31 earned the nickname “Karnslayer” during this assault, massacring the forces that rallied to stop its invasion. Once the force arrived at Atur it sacked the city, taking vengeance on the reanimation facilities that fueled the legions responsible for sacking Metrol previously in the war. Once the Cyran forces reached this objective, they recognized they could not occupy the city. The Cyran military retreated back across the border only to be obliterated a few months later on 20 Olarune 994 YK, the Day of Mourning. Since the war’s end, the city itself has largely been repaired, benefitting enormously from royal attention as well as the city’s undead laborers.

Under the general disarmament included in the Treaty of Thronehold, Kaius III agreed to inter Karnath’s standing reanimated armies in the crypts below Atur, where they await new orders.

GOVERNANCE

Rulership of Atur is not hereditary. It is a position granted to the Warden of the Lake of Shadows—a meritocratic title granted to whomever can survive the festering darkness found beneath Nighthold. When the Warden dies, any citizen of the duchy may seek to claim the title. This lethal process requires descending into the unnatural darkness and plunging a dagger into your own heart to consume and contain the unraveling shadows—those who fail are consumed by the shadows and never seen again, while those who succeed straddle the line of life and death, neither fully living nor fully undead. All Wardens learn to harness this power, but the depth of their mastery varies. Regardless, the title is both a blessing and a curse—it protects the bearer from age and disease, but slowly replaces their corporeal form with shadow. Only Duran has ever managed to escape this fate, which required even greater necromantic mastery through becoming a lich.

The current Grand Duke of Atur and Warden of Shadows, Warlord Syele Balich (reborn khoravar they/them), came into power five years ago after the previous Warden, Davian Karla, was killed in the Cyran offensive. A young prodigy, Syele represents a vibrant new movement to reclaim the Blood of Vol from its dark wartime history and affiliation with the Order of the Emerald Claw. Unfortunately, Syele must also contend with learning the ins and outs of diplomatic procedure; they come from common lineage and did not receive the education in high society that other warlords receive from birth.

Atur has relatively few counties, as its small size is largely taken up by unlivable terrain like the Ashen Spires. Some of its best land lies in the Ashen Valley, nestled between the peaks of the Ashen Spires. Land disputes between minor nobles over mining rights are common; veins of resources rarely respect pre-drawn borders.

CULTURAL HALLMARKS

Celebration of Life. While Karrns have a reputation for being emotionally closed off, life in Atur is the opposite. The Mark of Shadow has an ancient presence here, but less refined pleasures are abundant. Sex, gambling, feasts, and other indulgences are all found aplenty in Atur. The tourism and hospitality industries are core to the city’s economy. Even the rural areas surrounding the city offer

BONE WRANGLER

Medium Humanoid (any race), any alignment

Armor Class 11

Hit Points 9 (2d8)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	13 (+1)	10 (+0)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)

Skills Arcana +4, Religion +4

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 12

Languages Common, Elvish

Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)

Wrangle Bones. The Bone Wrangler casts *animate dead* as a ritual. If this casting is to animate a new skeleton or zombie, it requires an onyx or Khyber dragonshard worth at least 60 gp as an additional material component, which is consumed when the ritual is finished. A bone wrangler can have up to two skeletons or zombies under its control at a time.

ACTIONS

Dagger. *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 3 (1d4 + 1) piercing damage.

Spellcasting. The Bone Wrangler casts one of the following spells, using Intelligence as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 15).

At will: *mage hand*, *prestidigitation*, *guidance*

Ghallanda-licensed retreats for urbanites seeking to escape the city atmosphere.

Embrace of Undeath. Death is not the end in the duchy of Atur. Color-coded skeletal laborers clean city streets, till fields, and perform other menial tasks. Magewrights known as bone wranglers raise and maintain these skeletons, taking artistic pride in painting their creations. Citizens happily turn their bodies over to the state when they die, knowing that it will put them to good use to aid the living.

The Order of the Onyx Skull. After the Order of the Emerald Claw, the second-most prominent Seeker chivalric order was the Order of the Onyx Skull, which disbanded in 976 YK per Moranna’s edicts. Its members pioneered the techniques of the Bone Knight, and many have retired to become mentors to the next generation, as knight-errants. The headquarters of the order, just outside Atur’s walls, has been seized by the Karnathi state and is currently uninhabited.

THE ASHEN SPIRES

The alpine tundra of the Ashen Spires is milder than the Icetop Mountains to the northeast, despite the Ashen Spires being the taller mountain range. Trees gracefully transition to grasses and meadows from about 5500 to 6500 feet, depending on the mountain and which side of it one is on. The tallest mountain is Mount Tharzil, at just shy of 10,000 feet of elevation.

While the Ashen Spires have resources to exploit, they can be dangerous to travel through. Mundane animals such as saber-toothed tigers prowl the alpine forests and can become threats under duress or when modified by supernatural forces. Intelligent and monstrous predators like chimeras and perytons can also be found in the

mountains and can prove long-term threats to nearby communities. The Ashen Spires are even home to a Fernia manifest zone that hosts a reclusive phoenix, a subject of many folk tales about cheating death.

Deep within the Ashen Spires lies a secretive force that could prove instrumental if war were to break out, either within or beyond Karrnath. Kech Hashraac, the Keepers of Thunder, are experts in artillery. Tunnels within the Ashen Spires lead to the demiplane of Arak Yor, an unnatural and abandoned city filled with constructs maintaining ancient structures. Here, the *dar* of Kech Hashraac have learned seemingly ancient secrets of bizarre alchemy, vital tools which they hope to bring to any conflict for the throne of Dhakaan.

THE CITY OF ATUR

Nightlife defines the city of Atur, which has frighteningly short days due to a combination of the weather, the position of the mountains, and the Mabaran manifest zone. Many in Atur still feel the effects of the war, in particular the Cyran attack in 993. While the critical infrastructure of the city was swiftly repaired, less well-to-do and well-connected residents feel neglected by restoration efforts.

ATUR ACADEMY

The premiere school of necromancy on the continent, Atur Academy teaches both “externalist” methods that rely on Mabaran manifest zones and more common “Siberyan” magic. Headmaster Orthik “the Grim” maintains exacting standards—even during the war, the academy fought tooth and nail to keep enrollment down, eventually compromising by setting up affiliate programs to train the larger mass of necromantic mageswrights needed to maintain Karrnath’s reanimated legions.

The school has stood the test of time, dating from before Karn the Conqueror. Headmaster Orthik attained lichhood 200 years before the rise of Galifar and has served as headmaster for the majority of that period, only occasionally taking a sabbatical and temporarily turning over leadership. He relies on donations to feed his soul vessel, but there are enough Seekers who are willing to give themselves over at the end of their lives that his continued existence has never been a major concern.

While Atur Academy does have a conjuration program, it does not make pacts or otherwise traffic with fiends, despite allegations by foreign tabloids. Summoning circles are highly restricted and are used almost exclusively for knowledge acquisition; some secrets can only be pried from malefic spirits of Mabar or other planes. The most common deals are actually with angels of Syrania; the Throne of Death and its servants are well known to the scholars of Atur Academy.

The school’s actual necromantic studies have traditionally been focused on rituals; long-term animation relies on gemstones to hold its magic. Battlefield necromancy (a la *ray of sickness*) only came into prominence with the outbreak of the Last War; prior to the war, the idea of direct magical duels was thoroughly mocked as Aundairian foolishness (battles between necromantic creations have always been the acceptable way to resolve disputes). Today, battlefield manipulation of life and death is begrudgingly understood as a magical necessity.

CRIMSON MONASTERY

While the Blood of Vol largely practices in private elsewhere, the religion is celebrated in Atur. The Crimson Monastery, an enormous pyramid made from blood-red bricks and ebon mortar, is the center of worship for Seekers of the Divinity Within. Headed by the mummy-priest Malevenor and staffed by skeletons and oathbound mummies, the parallels to Shae Mordai are obvious—it is a deliberate mirror to Aerenal’s realm of the Undying.

The monastery itself is the central focus of the region’s manifest zone; its pyramidal shape helps channel the energies, with the most potent focused into a shrine encased in the building’s apex. The entire structure benefits from a *hallow* spell (undead are excluded from the spell’s first effect, and its second effect grants resistance to necrotic damage to Seekers of the Divinity Within). This spell can only be dispelled by destroying the bricks embedded into the structure that serve as permanent foci.

The interior feels cramped, despite having 15-foot ceilings and 10-foot-wide corridors. Small ritual chambers litter the building, also serving as private rooms where one can seek council with the undead inhabitants of the structure. Alternatively, a handful of larger shrines—each capable of seating scores of people—serve as more public areas where petitioners can make blood offerings. Either way, despite its imposing form, the Crimson Monastery has been built to serve the public.

The apex of the structure is a hollow room that serves as the high priest’s ossuary; it has the Necrotic Power, Radiant Void, and Hunger of Mabar planar properties (the building’s *hallow* spell protects Seekers from the Hunger of Mabar property). Here, Malevenor and the high priests before him have reached incredible heights of necromancy, performing feats impossible anywhere else on the continent.

MABARAN PROPERTIES

From Exploring Eberron

Necrotic Power. A creature has disadvantage on saving throws against necromancy spells. An undead creature has 2 extra hit points per Hit Die and advantage on saving throws against being turned or frightened.

Radiant Void. In order to cast a spell that deals radiant damage or restores hit points, a creature must succeed on a spellcasting ability check with a DC equal to 10 + the level of the spell. On a failed check, the spell is not cast and its spell slot is not expended, but the action is lost.

The Hunger of Mabar. Mabar consumes the life force of living things. For every minute a living creature spends in Mabar, it takes 10d6 points of necrotic damage. If this damage reduces a creature to 0 hit points, it immediately dies and its body crumbles into ash. Natives of Mabar, creatures that have resistance or immunity to necrotic damage, and creatures under the effects of a death ward spell are immune to the effects of this property.

GREAT HALL OF FEAST AND FORTUNE

While Olladra is generally disfavored by Karnathi Vassals, Atur's temple is the exception that proves the rule. While the building does have some spaces set aside specifically for sacred rituals, it largely functions as a high-class social establishment. Unlike some other venues of vice, the priests of Olladra care deeply about the well-being of its participants; people struggling with addictions are given assistance rather than exploited.

Despite the general animosity of Seekers to the worship of the Host, the Great Hall has a good reputation within the city. High Priestess Lorelea (halfling she/her) has successfully boosted the Feast Hall's profile with charity auctions and dinners, integrating the artistic and festive parts of the city.

NIGHTHOLD

A great rift to Mabar lurks in the depths of Nighthold, the royal retreat in Atur; while the Crimson Monastery channels the epicenter of the manifest zone, this rift is where the Warden of Shadows seals their life away to contain the Mabaran energies. While the Warden of Shadows lives, the rift is almost entirely dormant, but when the Warden dies it begins to fester—if selecting a new warden takes more than a few weeks, it begins to disgorge life-sapping undead.

Shortly after embracing the Blood of Vol, Kaius I began construction of a retreat for the royal family built atop the ancient ceremonial structure that holds the rift. During Davian's long tenure the rift had become an idle curiosity and attraction, allowing Nighthold to provide the royal family with a place to escape from the bustle of the court in Korth. The building is very defensible and was not breached during the 993 attack, but after Davian sacrificed himself the palace was evacuated until Syele claimed the title of Grand Warlord and Warden of Shadows.

Queen Etrigani has come to favor this residence, fascinated by the techniques and rituals the city's residents use to contain and channel the Mabaran manifest zone as well as the rift in the basement.

PALACE OF SHADOWS

While the shadow schism cut House Thuranni off from the majority of performance spaces in Khorvaire, it retained control of those in Karnath. The Palace of Shadows is an enormous theater in the heart of the city, hosting all sorts of performances that would be taboo in the refined halls of Korth and Karrlakton. The storytellers of the Palace of Shadows push the boundaries with graphic displays of humanoid bodies in ecstasy as well as horror, leveraging the city's necromantic specialties as well as the Mark of Shadow's traditional capacity for illusion.

The Palace is connected to the True Shaper's Demesne. Prior to the Shadow Schism, it was the home of the physical arts for all of Khorvaire, but after the split House Phiarlan founded a new Demesne of Shape in Thaliost. The renamed True Shaper's Demesne is a multi-level structure; the ground level has space for both a museum and several galleries, while the second floor serves as administrative offices. Below the structure is an extensive series of studios, workshops, and other creative spaces that expand far beyond the footprint of the ground floor.



KARRLAKTON

The smallest of the duchies, Karrlakton occupies Karnath's south-facing border with Cyre and is best known for being the home of House Deneith. The duchy is less urban than Korth, as Karrlakton is the only city of note within its borders. The mile-high dead gray mists of the Mourmland are visible even as far inland as the southern border of the Nightwood, and its presence has weighed heavily on the minds of the residents of the duchy for the past four years. The Duchy's eastern and western borders are marked by small tributary rivers that feed into the Cyre River.

HISTORY

Within two centuries of humanity settling in Karnath and the founding of the original Kingdom of Karrlakton, a curious new birthmark appeared among a few different families within Western Karnath. The Mark of Sentinel was the first dragonmark to appear among humanity, and its powers of awareness and protection gave these families a leg up, allowing them to become the first batch of warlords.

As these early warlords were establishing themselves, events in Aerenal led to a mass exodus. Many of these elves arrived in Karrlakton, but their presence was unwelcome at best. After they were discovered to harbor vampires, the elves and their allies were attacked by the human warlords and forced to flee north, through the Nightwood, eventually arriving at the head of the Karn river where they would found the city of Atur.

Just under a millennia after the arrival of humanity, Karn the Conqueror was born in Karrlakton. Presaging Galifar's unification of all the houses under him, Karn's greatest diplomatic triumph was uniting the Sentinel-marked families into House Deneith while ensuring that they were loyal and subservient to him. Deftly navigating

the cutthroat political world of Western Karrnath, he gave them control of the city's central keep, which would become Sentinel Tower. With this magically enhanced army of premiere warriors, Karrn was able to march west and conquer Korth, from where he united all of Karrnath.

Karrlakton's status as the number two duchy was cemented during the thousand-year period following Karrnath's unification. While the city's harbor is not as high quality as Korth's, it's still conveniently on the waterway and engages in plenty of trade. Marriages between noble families from Korth and Karrlakton have always been common, with Karrlakton earning a reputation as a quieter and less conniving court than the capital.

Galifar ir'Wynarn was born in Karrlakton, but as a child moved with his family to the court in Korth. While he did not explicitly visit political favors upon the duchy, the security needs of the early kingdom deeply enriched House Deneith. Those riches flowed out to the rest of the duchy, as Karrlakton became the central home for Deneith's formerly scattered training programs. This continued until Jarot's reign; even without the general threat of war, House Deneith mercenaries were always in demand to deal with internal security and frontier conflicts.

Like the Duchy of Korth, Karrlakton was invaded repeatedly throughout the Last War, primarily by Cyran forces crossing the river. The city, protected by Sentinel Tower, was virtually impregnable, but the surrounding countryside did not benefit from the aegis of House Deneith. The town of Vurgenslye, on the western edge of the duchy, was the site of several pitched battles between reinforcements from Korth and the Cyran military.

Unfortunately, Karrlakton has not been able to recover from the ravages of war like Korth. The Day of Mourning immediately thrust the duchy into turmoil, as panicking Cyran refugees crossed the river en masse. Unlike the tragedies that befell those fleeing into Valenar, Karrnath generally refrained from violence against refugees, but neither did it provide the aid and welcome that Breland and Thrane did. Instead, the refugees were rounded up and

held as prisoners of war for two years until their release was negotiated as part of the Treaty of Thronehold. The camps they were held in have been mostly dismantled, but their effect on the landscape is still plenty evident.

GOVERNANCE

The Duchess of Karrlakton, Olivier ir'Mira (human she/her), is a fierce leader and veteran who's led her forces in dozens of battles. Her personal prowess is unquestionable, having graduated Rekkenmark with top marks in both battlefield leadership and dueling. She's survived several assassination attempts, including one from the traitorous Order of the Emerald Claw, without even acquiring a scar.

Politically, Duchess ir'Mira is an ally of the crown but has questions about Kaius III's current goals and choice of spouse. Despite her successes in the war, she has no interest in restarting the conflict; she's repeatedly rebuffed entreaties from the pro-war caucus At All Costs. She also keeps one eye on House Deneith, recognizing that the Blademark Guild's strength combined with the Baron's ambition is a cause for concern in the post-Thronehold order.

Beneath the duchess, Karrlakton is divided into a handful of counties. The war provided plenty of opportunities for turnover, as military expectations significantly increased the mortality rate among nobility. Those that survived have found mixed success in the post-war order; falling tax revenues from depopulation combined with sustained military obligations have made some sympathetic to the forces arrayed against the crown.

CULTURAL HALLMARKS

Paper. In addition to agriculture, Karrlakton's signature product is paper. Mills along the Cyre River boomed during the 9th century and were lucky enough to avoid destruction by Cyran artillery during the Last War. The appearance of the dead-gray mists has unnerved enough people over the last four years that the mills are struggling to find enough workers to meet demand, a weakness some laborers are seeing as an opportunity to fight back against hazardous conditions and the unjust Code of Kaius that protects them.

Order of the Blackened Sky. While Karrnath is most often associated with the directly martial gods like Dol Dorn, Onatar's role in stoking the industry of war is also important to Karrnath's military success. After Regent Moranna ended the Blood of Vol's elevated status, Olivier's predecessor—the late Philip ir'Mira—founded a new order focused on mixing traditional Karrnathi martial practices with artifice. The Order of the Blackened Sky remains one of the most socially open of Karrnath's orders, welcoming people from all walks of life who embrace its tenets of curiosity and embracing technological change. The group's role evolved in 994, as horrors periodically left the mists to terrorize Karrnathi citizens. Olivier charged its members with protecting the border, a role they gladly embraced with the cessation of ordinary hostilities. Today, members of the Order of the Blackened Sky fight Mournland monstrosities with all sorts of alchemical concoctions. The order's commander, Evetius ir'Denka (they/them), is always looking for independent groups to gather intelligence and material from inside the mists.



Fashion. While Karrns are typecast as grim and covered up in heavy cloaks, Karrlakton is different. The duchy's relatively southern location and proximity to the Cyre River keep it warmer and wetter than the rest of Karnath. Far more important, however, is the presence of House Deneith. While all the houses have enjoyed a certain immunity to petty regulations such as sumptuary laws that restrict fashions, only House Deneith has publicly *flaunted* rules and standards for dress. The house's signature green, yellow, and purple colors date back to when a Galifaran monarch banned the colors and the baron of the house decided to outfit their soldiers in poofy, garish tunics, a fashion that periodically returns and has become a permanent feature of the duchy as a whole.

THE CITY OF KARRLAKTON

Another of Karnath's ancient cities, the city of Karrlakton sits on the Cyre River directly across from the imposing wall of the dead gray mists. Fear of the Mourndland has led to an exodus of people from the city over the last four years, and the city has attracted a plethora of doom sayers who say they are eager to witness the apocalypse. Despite this, the defining feature of Karrlakton remains Sentinel Tower, the home of House Deneith.

THE DAISON INSTITUTE

After Baron Breven d'Deneith and Duchess Olivier, Loyal Daison (human he/him) is the third wealthiest and most powerful figure in Karrlakton. The head of the Aurum branch in the city and a recent inductee of the Platinum Concord, Loyal Daison is primarily defined by his unbound avarice. Having started as a contractor during the war, he's spent two decades building his fortune and becoming the largest landowner in the city of Karrlakton, swooping in to buy properties damaged by the war and turning them into technically livable housing. His abusive practices as a landlord have earned him the nickname "The Slumlord of Karrlakton."

The Daison Institute is an important facet of Loyal's greed. In the aftermath of the Treaty of Thronehold, Loyal Daison successfully trapped many Cyrans in exploitative leases; he has used this as leverage to get land rights to sections of the Mourndland. The Daison Institute is the other half of this exploitation, an austere collection of sages and arcanists developing new techniques for exploring, cataloging, and "reclaiming" (looting) the Mourndland. The institute regularly sponsors expeditions, which might either be a source of backing or source of rivals for a group of adventurers.

SENTINEL TOWER

The home of House Deneith, Sentinel Tower dominates Karrlakton's skyline. The enormous fortress serves all sorts of functions and contains everything from meeting rooms to training courtyards to smithies and even taverns. It's also the home base of the Sentinel Marshals, an elite group of mercenary law enforcement specialists that tracks down international criminals. The majority of the city's economic activity is tied to Sentinel Tower—feeding, clothing, arming, and entertaining the mercenaries constitute an enormous body of work.

THE IR'MIRA ESTATE

Unlike many other notable buildings in the city, the duchess' home is *not* a fortress, but a pleasant estate with

gardens and other fineries. Karrlakton's ruling family carefully kept it from wartime conversions, although some features did suffer from neglect when times were tough. The duchess began restoration efforts immediately upon the formal end of the war, breathing life back into many dead and barren rooms. Guests are typically most interested in seeing the estate's expansive ballroom, where Karrlakton's finest have danced the night away for generations.

MIRA BALLET COMPANY

The premiere arts establishment of Karrlakton is owned by the ir'Mira family, but productions are managed by House Thuranni's former members of the Demesne of Motion. The company's most popular show is the annual winter production of "Second Wishes," a story in which a woman wishes to become a princess and gets wrapped up in the scheme of the Second Son when she realizes that royalty isn't everything she imagined it would be. The ballet company supports itself the rest of the year with smaller productions featuring the stories of characters like the Forgotten Prince and the Forest Queen.

TEMPLE OF THE BROKEN BLADE

The continent's largest temple dedicated solely to Dol Dorn is not a traditional temple; instead, it's an enormous stadium. The large field is used for religious services and individual training most days, but it hosts competitions for each of Dol Dorn's feast days which come once every sixteen days. While outright bloodsport was outlawed several centuries ago, modern challenges involving unarmed combat remain popular. Organized crime in Karrlakton runs through the temple, with gambling rings and other unsavory conduct discretely managed by high priest Theda Dorn (dwarf she/her).

Attached to the stadium is a fortified building that serves as a monastery for the Order of the Broken Blade. House Deneith has a close relationship with the monastery; several high-ranking members of the house have achieved the title of Blademaster. Sentinel Marshals especially like to train with the martial artists of the Broken Blade, as their job with law enforcement is much more likely to involve unarmed combat than those of the Blademasters or Defenders guilds.

THE DAISON FORGE

Karnath's largest single industrial plant is in Karrlakton. Although the metalworking equipment is supplied by House Cannith, the forge was originally a temple to Onatar before being bought out by Loyal Daison a decade ago. The foundry is located along the river and is surrounded by slums also owned by Loyal Daison. During the war it received shipments of raw materials via lightning rail, turned them into arms and armor, and then shipped them back both by rail and along the river, either to Karnath's own armies or to its allies. Today, the furnaces produce civilian goods, such as construction materials, under miserable conditions; the hours are long and brutal, but Loyal Daison has used the law and economic manipulation to ensure he has a ready supply of backs to break toiling away for his profits. Duchess Olivier has thus far ignored Daison's abuses, as most people trapped are Cyran survivors rather than Karnathi citizens.



KORTH

The capital of the nation, the duchy of Korth is the largest and most populous of the eight duchies that make up Karnath. The vast majority of the population lives along Scions Sound and the Karrn River, while the three forests it claims—the Karnnwood, Nightwood, and Rekkenwood—are mostly uninhabited. Small villages and farmsteads cover the plains beyond the woods, governed by nobles of varying stature living in manors and castles. Of all the people of Karnath, those in Korth have always been the most accessible to the wider world and are largely responsible for shaping the opinion of peoples beyond Karnath.

HISTORY

The oldest of the duchies, the Kingdom of Korth was among the first human kingdoms established on the continent. Human structures here date back more than two millennia, although few have survived that long due to natural decay and the armies that periodically march through on a warpath. When Karrn conquered the city, he recognized its strategic location and made it his new capital, leaving behind Karrlakton and his lands there. From Korth he expanded north, east, and south, filling out the modern nation of Karnath.

This pre-Galifaran unified Karnath often found itself in conflict with its neighbors; while Karrn's attempt to unite the continent was certainly the most successful and best known of this time period, various Karnnathi rulers throughout history have picked fights with their neighbors to the west and south. Ancient fortifications and the legacy of conflict still dot the landscape of the greater region, especially on the western bank of Scions Sound where the mages of Thaliost pushed back against Karnnathi aggression. The two longest standing of these are the enormous castles now known as Tanar Rath and Loran

Rath, which flank the Karrn River. Fortunately, Galifaran advances in arcane science enabled the dispelling and disarmament of almost all the lingering curses and other threats leftover from this era.

The War of the Mark and the founding of the Twelve were critical developments in Korth's relationship with arcane science; prior to the Twelve's establishment, Karnath was completely bereft of institutional magic education. While the dragonmarked houses and the families that composed them were very different at the time, the Twelve's mission to study and harness the power of dragonmarks had an immediate positive impact on the lives of the people of Korth. Unfortunately, many of these gains were not widely shared throughout the rest of the Kingdom of Karnath, adding significant material dimensions to the long-standing cultural gap between Korth and the rest of the nation.

What Karrn did to Karrlakton, Galifar did to Korth—taking a conquered capital as his new home, leaving behind the old one. While neither was abandoned, there is a bitterness to losing one's status as the most favored child. Princes and princesses of Karnath were never first in line to the throne of Galifar, always secretly hoping that their eldest sibling might fall sick or otherwise depart the throne. Tradition dictated that they ruled the province from Korth, but since the prior ruler of the Duchy of Korth would be displaced, a house swap was necessary. The incoming prince or princess would travel to each of the eight other duchies and entertain suitors before choosing a spouse. The previous rulers of Korth would then be granted a lower title as replacement, traditionally in whichever duchy had ascended to the capital—an arrangement that conveniently spread Wynarn blood throughout nearly every noble family in the nation.

The breakout of the Last War thrust the Duchy of Korth into the front lines. Aundairian, Cyran, and—rarely—Thranish forces crossed into Karnath on numerous campaigns, the most successful of which were the 939–940 siege by Aundair and the 936 and 971–973 sieges by Cyre that reached (but never breached) the capital. The scars of these campaigns remain; areas littered with blast mines have been marked off limits, with *magic mouth* spells acting as warnings for anyone who approaches them. Regent Moranna capitalized on the latter Cyran campaign to institute various infrastructural reforms, such as rebuilding old cow paths to follow orderly designs that would be more accommodating for vehicular traffic. Some of these reforms were controversial, but Kaius III continued his aunt's renovations both inside and outside the walls of the capital.

GOVERNANCE

While Kaius governs the nation from his palace, Crownhome, he does not claim sole rulership over the Duchy of Korth. Archduchess Syele ir'Wynarn, Kaius III's older cousin through his Aunt Moranna, manages the more regular and mundane jobs of ruling such as tax collection, land disputes, and other sundry things.

Some court observers find it unusual that Gaius, the King's younger brother, doesn't serve as Duke, unlike the first in line to the throne usually had for the past century. Instead, he's stationed in Thrane as part of an exchange of royal family members between Breland, Karnath, and

Thrane. Meanwhile, Borina and Halix of Breland as well as one of Blood Regent Diani's descendants reside in Korth.

Despite ruling other duchies, the ancestors of Renn ir'Tanar of Narath and Charl ir'Loran of Lyodnica were granted land near the mouth of the Karrn River within Korth at the outbreak of the Last War. The twin fortresses Tanar Rath and Loran Rath served as key defensive rallying points throughout the Last War and continue to boast formidable garrisons of troops to this day.

CULTURAL HALLMARKS

Pro-Treaty. The people of the Duchy of Korth have the most to gain from the new peace and strongly support Kaius's efforts in that regard. Not only are they the best positioned to succeed in international trade, but they bore the brunt of the war's devastation.

Vassals. The people of Korth are strong followers of the Sovereign Host; the Blood of Vol never had the same degree of popularity here that it did in the rest of the nation. The heroic actions of Prelate Alinda Roerith in the siege of the capital in the early 970s only cemented their support for the Church of the Sovereign Host.

Arcane Science. While traditional Karrnathi values of martial prowess have always been prominent within Korth, interest in arcane science as well as more mundane pursuits of knowledge are much higher in this duchy than the others. Folk from elsewhere in Karrnath sometimes see these pursuits as soft, but the success of Rekkenmark's evocation program has done much to quell this dissent.

Since Kaius III ascended to the throne in 990, Korth has become the most industrialized of the eight duchies. Each year more workers use their general education (administered by priests of Aureon) to work in factories owned by the wealthy with arcane devices produced by Cannith East. The lack of freedom under the Code of Kaius and wartime pressures have thus far suppressed investigation into workplace abuses and health hazards posed by these new factories.

THE KARRNWOOD

Wild and expansive, the Karrnwood occupies more than half of the duchy. Almost the entirety of the woods belong to the duchy, with the exception of the northwestern woods that are part of the Duchy of Narath.

Unique spiritual practices prevail in the communities along the Karrnwood's border. The Three Faces of the Wild—venerating a balance between Arawai, Balinor, and the Devourer—is a particularly common variant of worship of the Host here. These beliefs often interweave with the veneration of fey spirits, as the Vassals here can see a dryad as not just representative of the Forest Queen but also Arawai. Some communities emphasize generosity and hospitality when incorporating fey traditions, expecting that their good nature will be rewarded, while others emphasize the tricks and rituals necessary to keep fey compliant.

The Karrnwood is a true wilderness, as it is simply too large and too frigid to be tamed. Ancient mysteries lurk within its depths, unseen by humanoids for eons. While the fey are the best-known supernatural force in the woods, others surely exist—dark and twisted woods tied to Mabar, bountiful wilds tied to Lamannia, and ever-frozen forests tied to Risia. Similarly, connections to Khyber could give footholds to all manner of foul corruption, from the

hungry swarms of Valaara to the twisted growths of Avassh to strange and unknown shadow demiplanes or even overlords.

THE CITY OF KORTH

An ancient metropolis, Korth is managed by Civic Minister Hyran ir'Tennet, whose authority covers all civilian matters, while security (both internal and external) is managed by General Yorin Thauram. Five wards, divided by riverside bluffs, constitute the city and are individually managed by appointees under the Civic Minister. Most of the city is strictly patrolled by the White Lions, the city's military police force, but they tend to leave the Low Ward alone.

HIGHCOURT WARD

While generally serving as the ward for Korth's well-to-do—nobles from across the nation maintain secondary residences here—the highlight of Highcourt is Crownhome, King Kaius's fortress-palace. Two massive rocky pillars flank the stronghold, which extends in a long line between them. The original structure dates back to before Karrn, although it has been restored and heavily fortified multiple times, both by the Kingdom of Galifar and during the Last War. Crownhome has never been breached in a siege; even Karrn's victory two millennia ago required a brutal starvation campaign. Today, in addition to housing over a thousand soldiers, the building is outfitted with an enormous collection of siege engines that can reach all the way out to the Karrn River to defend against a naval assault.

Despite taking a wife, Kaius maintains a harem in the eastern wing of the building. Traditionally these residences are reserved for the family of the monarch, but since the Treaty of Thronehold the king's brother and sister have lived abroad. The harem consists of about twenty adults and is safeguarded by Beauty (warforged she/her), a trustworthy and loyal servant of the King. In truth, the harem exists to sustain Kaius' vampiric needs; most are followers of the Blood of Vol who believe that Kaius will find a solution to the curse of mortality.

TEMPLE WARD

The largest structure in the Temple Ward is the Cathedral of the Sovereign Host. The cathedral suffered heavy damage during the war, but in the past two years it's been mostly reconstructed and is even grander than before. Its colossal interior features a magically animated starscape, which scholars of Aureon consult to attempt to divine the future.

Beyond the worship of the Sovereign Host, Korth is home to a mid-size Church of the Silver Flame, one of a small handful in the nation. This small community suffered during the early decades of the war due to both its association with the new theocracy of Thrane, which had broken its alliance with Karrnath, and the establishment of the Blood of Vol as Karrnath's state religion. Still, no official action was ever taken against the church, and it largely survived intact.

While the Temple Ward used to have many places to worship the Blood of Vol, Kaius banned open worship by Seekers within the city. Former places of worship have been converted to a variety of purposes, from night life to housing.



The Temple Ward is also home to the University of Korth. While not nearly as well regarded as the University of Wynarn in Fairhaven, the hostilities between Aundair and Karrnath significantly elevated this school's status within the nation. This institution does not teach arcane magic; students interested in becoming wizards typically attend either the University of Rekkenmark, join the Twelve, or during the war would go to Atur and become a state necromancer. The school is best known for its History department, but has bulked up other non-magical studies like language arts, mathematics, and philosophy.

COMMERCE WARD

The most striking feature of the Commerce Ward is the Tower of the Twelve, an enormous 13-spired building that floats above the city. Most of the structure is filled with arcane laboratories and libraries devoted to eldritch subjects. This research institute also holds meeting rooms for the dragonmarked houses to resolve their differences and strike new terms of cooperation. Industrialized lifts using the principles of the *levitate* spell allow both people and cargo to get up to and down from the airborne structure.

Korth was the first Karrnathi city to build an airship docking tower, located not far from the Tower of the Twelve. Completed in 993 YK, it quickly became the preferred mode of transportation for every baron except Kwanti d'Orien. Local service includes Atur, Karrlakton, Rekkenmark, and Vedykar, with international flights connecting through Thaliost and Flamekeep. The long flights to Krona Peak and Taer Valaestas are much rarer and usually stop in Atur and Karrlakton respectively to ensure the elemental is as fresh as possible for the trip. Still, House Kundarak and House Lyrandar's extensive holdings in those cities ensure regular traffic to and from Korth. House Ghallanda has thus far resisted installation of a docking tower in Gatherhold, limiting visitors to those willing to take the long Lightning Rail trip south from Karrlakton.

Beyond the Tower of the Twelve, Korth is home to a number of major house enclaves. Cannith, Deneith, Jorasco, Kundarak, Medani, Orien, and Thuranni all have significant institutional presence in the city. Adventurers seeking out the services of an Heir of Siberys or one of those houses have a good chance of finding them in Korth.

COMMUNITY WARD

While primarily residential, the community ward is also home to the famed arts productions of Korth. Recently there have been some grumblings about censorship; the khoravar playwright Asta Brand fled to Droaam after the Civic Minister, Hyran ir'Tennet, took offense at her opera, "Army of the Damned," and ordered her assets seized for its criticism of the Code of Kaius and the Karrnathi military.

In the eastern part of the ward, a small community of goblins has taken sudden interest in the caves that pockmark the bluffs separating the commerce and community wards. These caves, considered haunted by locals due to the huge skeletal hands embedded into the walls, were used for storing emergency food and water supplies during the Last War. These goblins are secretly from Kech Nasaar and are taking advantage of the abandoned caves to investigate the ancient history of the city. Unfortunately, the Order of the Emerald Claw has taken similar interest in these deep, undocumented parts of the tunnels and are trying to pin their own covert misdeeds on the goblins.

LOW WARD

Originally called the "Low Ward" for its proximity to the water and propensity for flooding, the Low Ward today is a tangled mess of residences and shady businesses. Originally driven by slumlords and now reinforced by businesses seeking to exploit cheap labor, the city has a semi-official policy of neglecting the Low Ward.

The ward is also home to Korth's immigrant populations, small as they are. Halflings from the Talenta Plains, Cyrans who chose not to leave for New Cyre, dwarves from the Mror Holds—all of these groups eke out an existence in the often-lawless Low Ward. Each of these groups has developed their own ways of protecting themselves from the predations of the ward's gangs. If a group of adventurers runs into trouble, roll or choose from the Low Ward Gangs table.

LOW WARD GANGS

D6 Gang

- 1 "The Dead-Gray Knives," orphaned Cyrans who make their own way with petty crime
- 2 "Utig's Hammers," a well-established dwarven group running a protection racket
- 3 "Silent Masks," a ring of halfling catburglars that wear Talentan masks to disguise themselves during heists
- 4 "Third Street Swords," a group of dishonorably discharged veterans of various ancestries
- 5 "The Adamantine Fist," warforged bruisers-for-hire that have secret ties to the Lord of Blades
- 6 "The Serpent's Fangs," petty thieves that have secretly sworn themselves to the overlord Eldrantulku and slowly transformed into yuan-ti

The most infamous criminal of the Low Ward is known as The Midwife; rather than delivering newborn infants, her impeccable forgery work delivers new identities. While the scale of her operation remains small and her resources limited, she's the best at what she does. In addition to papers for anywhere in Khorvaire, she's recently acquired the psionic inks and other materials necessary to forge

Riedran documents; an invaluable resource for anyone trying to sneak into the xenophobic empire.

THE NIGHTWOOD

Many of Khorvaire's ghost stories begin in a small community on the edge of the Nightwood, an area thoroughly littered with Mabaran manifest zones. Over the millennia, all sorts of dark forces have spawned from or migrated to these gloomy woods: corpses there can naturally reanimate as zombies, wights use the manifest zones to bargain with the spirits of Mabar, and vampires have dwelled in the area since they first arrived from Aerenal. The wood's proximity to Korth has prompted many escaped convicts to try to disappear into the woods rather than face the hangman; the lucky ones simply die, rather than becoming tortured creatures eternally reenacting their crimes upon the living.

Legends of the Nightwood suggest some kind of festering wound at its heart may be the source of its grim atmosphere. It's possible that the region's connection to undeath isn't purely from Mabar, but is also due to a rift to the domain of Katashka or another overlord. Whatever the case, little is known about the region's ancient history—the affliction the Nightwood suffers from may be the result of a long-forgotten conflict. Groups such as the Order of the Emerald Claw may wish to recreate this powerful undead influence elsewhere, but it may also be possible to undo the region's cursed nature.

Despite the periodic risk of monsters, many people living on the edge of the woods have found its Mabaran connections to be valuable. Plants that survive growing in Mabaran zones have a wide variety of uses, from Jorasco disinfectants to magical waste disposal. Nightwood Ale relies on the area's properties, and Seekers have numerous rituals that utilize its abundant necrotic energy.

REKKENMARK

The youngest of Karrnath's major cities yet still nearly a millennium old, the city of Rekkenmark grew up around the academy founded by Prince Karrn. A manifest zone tied to Shavarath that enhances battle acuity and training lies at the heart of the academy; today it serves as the academy's primary training grounds. For over 800 years Rekkenmark prepared Galifar's greatest officers; some have been immortalized in song and story, while others have become infamous for their cowardice and corruption. The outbreak of the Last War set the students of Rekkenmark against each other, each nation forced to form their own rival schools. Rekkenmark has re-opened for international students, but an uneasy air hangs over the question of whether these classmates will, like their predecessors, soon find themselves facing off against each other in the name of king and country.

The city itself also suffered on account of the war; Aundair captured Rekkenmark early on in an invasion from Thaliost, and Kaius I retaliated by destroying parts of the White Arch Bridge to cut off the Aundairian supply route in 899 YK. While Orien heirs were able to repair the bridge and Karrnath recaptured the city, the bridge was fully blown to bits by saboteurs of unknown nationality only three decades later in 928 YK, shortly after Thrane captured Thaliost for what would be the final time. Cutting off this critical trade route wasn't the end of the city's woes; air raids by Thranish wyverns ravaged it several

times throughout the war, cementing the hostility between Karrns and Thrane.

With the destruction of the White Arch Bridge, getting to Rekkenmark is much harder than it used to be; the city is built adjacent to steep cliffs and has little ability to accept traffic from the water. While it does have a freshly constructed airship docking tower, few routes stop in Rekkenmark compared to nearby Thaliost and Korth. Travelers to Rekkenmark from Western Khorvaire who can't afford an airship ride usually travel by water from Flamekeep to Korth, then use the lightning rail station in Korth to reach the city.

THE ORDER OF REKKENMARK

Graduates of the academy are almost always inducted into the Order of Rekkenmark, earning an opal ring to signify their membership. The head of the order is First Warlord Gruden ir'Erdei, the Duke of Vulyar. Prior to the war, members of the Order were spread around Khorvaire, but in the intervening century the Order has formally ejected the surviving non-Karrnathi members. Today it primarily functions to introduce camaraderie between all Karrnathi officers, seeking to cut through the vertical loyalty of regional factionalism.

A secret society of seditious warlords has formed in the upper echelons of the Order of Rekkenmark; known as At All Costs, it seeks to unseat Kaius and return Karrnath to its true destiny of conquering all of Khorvaire. The group has spent the last few years accumulating power and influence, including allying with business interests, but it's got a long way to go before it can seriously contemplate a coup.

THE REKKENWOOD

Corralled between Rekkenmark and the Karrn River, the northern edge of the Rekkenwood bleeds away into farmland. The forest is a contested zone between the industrial might of Karrnath and the Forest Queen. The wealthy lords and merchants who live near the forest—not to mention the military minds of the city—see the archfey as yet another foe to be conquered and forced to submit in pursuit of material gains.

Historically, the fey have been more than capable of protecting their sacred spaces. But after a century of warfare, arcane military science has advanced to the point that Karrnath can successfully wage war against the Forest Queen's servants. Now, Karrnathi soldiers use *magic circle* to protect themselves from the fey while cutting down dryads' trees and uprooting pixie burrows. The Forest Queen, in turn, has escalated—beasts given her blessing, enormous and monstrous bears and boars and other wild things, have gone on lethal rampages.

Without a war to draw the focus and attention of Karrnath's industrial military machine, encroachments and assaults on the fey places of the Rekkenwood will only continue. The consequences of this are unknown; the desecration of the Forest Queen's spaces could have untold ecological consequences, and she might escalate further.



LYODNICA

Despite rivaling Korth in overall area, Lyodnica is the least populous of Karrnath's duchies due to its climate. The large central expanse is bitterly cold yet arid tundra, while the Icewood and the Icetop Mountains are filled with hostile creatures. The duchy's inhabitants are most concentrated along the Iceflow River, facilitating what little trade occurs between Lyodnica and the rest of the world. Since Narath's destruction, Lyodnica has struggled to support its western neighbor in the Bitter Sea; the shallow river delta means blue water ships can't make it far upriver.

HISTORY

Even the Dhakaani Empire failed to meaningfully colonize the area now recognized as Lyodnica; the wet and cold winters bring heavy snows, but the region is too warm to sustain permafrost, transforming the surface into a soggy morass in the summer. Even beyond these fields, the empire had little interest in the Icewood or the Bitter Sea—everything they needed could be found below in the tunnels of Khyber, away from the biting cold that defines the region.

When humanity came west from the Lhazaar Principalities people settled along the northern coast of what would become Karrnath. Karrn Bay and the river delta that flowed into it were relatively hospitable, even if the surrounding terrain was difficult to expand into. Hostile fey in both the Karrnwood and Icewood, as well as upriver in the Iceflow River, all made expanding beyond the river delta impossible.

Out of all the duchies, Lyodnica was least affected by Karrn the Conqueror's ambitions. Magical development had begun to connect the people of the duchy with the rest of Karrnath, but it wasn't until nearly the reign of Galifar that the people of Ice had regular contact and trade during

the winter months. Heavy snows on the Mamont Tundra blocked southward egress, while icebergs in the Bitter Sea frequently made leaving the protections of Karrn Bay impossible.

The Kingdom of Galifar failed its many attempts to further build out Lyodnica's capabilities. Karrnathi princes and Lyodnican warlords often fell into the trap of thinking that arcane science could finally clear the way for Ice to connect with the rest of the nation, only to find that the combination of harsh winters and boggy summers was far stronger than any spell or device. It wasn't until Jarot's reign and his son Kaius I's governorship that icebreaker ships, fitted with adamantine hulls, could reliably keep the seaways clear. In the south, several attempts to build a lightning rail connecting Ice to the rest of the nation failed as conductor stones sunk into the summer morass or were lost to winter blizzards.

The advent of the Last War brought significant attention to the duchy, as the conjunction of advances in ship design and the outbreak of conflict in the Bitter Sea made Karrn Bay a focal point of the war. While Narath's port was always better for ship building, during the winter months far more ships could take shelter in Karrn Bay. Naval mines developed by House Cannith helped protect the bay from Aundairian raids, while shallow-hulled boats ferried crew and cargo between the anchored ships and the town of Ice.

Today, Lyodnica is the target of a resettlement effort. Once again, the crown and the duchy leadership are convinced that advances in arcane science will allow for more permanent settlements in the harsh northern expanses. Engineers and artificers continue to develop plans to build a proper shipyard in Karrn Bay, dredging where needed while accounting for the harsh winter storms that blow in from the Bitter Sea.

GOVERNANCE

Warlord Charlir'Loran (human he/him) governs Lyodnica. An ostensibly close ally of the crown, his family has held the lands around Loran Rath since early in the war. In truth, he yearns for a return to the days of the war, when glory could be found on the battlefield and at sea. He has an almost Aundairian belief in the poetry of the conflict, and has a large number of art commissions that celebrate victories won by Lyodnican soldiers. While it's not unusual for a noble to be detached from the costs of the war, Warlord ir'Loran takes it to an extreme with an almost singular focus on the "glories" of the war. His children are no better, positioned in plum military positions throughout the nation. He sees Kaius III as a pale imitation of the greater kings before him, a weakling who caved in the Treaty of Thronehold and denied Karrnath dominion over the continent. While not a sophisticated politician, he's secretly a member of At All Costs and would happily throw his lot in with anyone who sought to overthrow Kaius and start a new war.

CULTURAL HALLMARKS

Mammoths. Enormous wooly mammoths wander the Mamont Tundra, dominating the cold and arid expanse. Nomadic groups of humans long ago domesticated the creatures, harvesting their wool for trade and survival. Mammoth wool is best when the animal is young—the first shear is highly prized for making the soft and warm winter garments worn by Karrnath's upper class.

Risian Manifest Zones. Not only is the duchy cold due to natural climate processes, but its unusually large number of Risian manifest zones augment the conditions. Most simply embody the obvious traits of the plane, possessing the Lethal Cold and/or Empowered Ice properties from *Exploring Eberron*, but areas with the Preservation and Stillness of Flesh traits have been found in the Mamont Tundra. The manifest zones are cold year-round, an exception to the summer thaw, and exacerbate the lack of precipitation in the tundra.

Religious Syncretism. Without regular and consistent access to the central Karrnathi government, the people of Lyodnica have a unique relationship with faith. Local customs involving the fey and primal spirits are blended with old traditions carried on from Sarlona, Galifar-era worship of the sovereign host, and a smattering of Seeker beliefs. The periodic attempts at settlement bring in new perspectives, although they are quickly tempered by the harsh reality of living in the frigid north.

ICE

Situated just south of the Iceflow River Delta, the town of Ice sits on a particularly wide and easy part of the river. Traffic between the town and ships anchored in Karrn Bay is the primary way goods are exchanged between the duchy and the wider world.

RIVER SPIRITS

Life in Ice is possible due to long-standing negotiations with the local spirits, including the spirit of the Iceflow River, Lyodnica. In exchange for annual, ritualized sacrifices, the spirits continue to bless the town with good conditions. However, continued industrial development might threaten this relationship, posing unforeseen risks to the town and the region that depends on it.

ICEHOLD

The seat of the duchy is a heavily fortified keep in the center of town. Ice, of course, has never been seriously threatened by an outside force, but the ir'Loran family has nonetheless taken it upon themselves to turn their home into a fortress. On the inside are displays of remarkable wealth, including an entire taxidermized wooly rhino slain by Starovolkov ir'Loran, the legendary swordsman who trained Jarot ir'Wynarn.

ICETOP MOUNTAINS

Rising along the eastern border of the duchy, the Icetop Mountains are the source for the Iceflow River. While not as tall as the Ashen Spires, the Icetop Mountains are topped by an enormous Risian manifest zone that preserves their harsh conditions year-round. The mountains provide just enough glacial melt to maintain the Iceflow River, as the manifest zone becomes less intensely cold at its edges.

Despite their seeming inhospitality, the Icetop Mountains do have a few permanent communities. One such group is a tribe of goliaths called the "Stone Throwers" who have lived in the mountains since before humans arrived; some conspiracists believe these Risia-touched folk are the descendants of the "Forgotten Peoples" that lived in Khorvaire during the Age of Monsters. Other, more horrifying creatures stalk the mountain passes—demons and devils tied to Risia

sometimes manifest from the ice and snow, alongside somewhat more mundane threats like ice trolls.

The mountains are a surprising repository of mineral wealth, buried beneath the ice and snow. Since the secession of the Mror Holds, increased attention has been paid to extracting these resources. The native goliaths have allied with the ir'Loran family in this endeavor, providing muscle both to protect the mining operations from supernatural threats and to pull the riches from the mines.

THE ICEWOOD

The wild, northernmost wood of Karrnath is a subject of active exploration, with both government and private sponsors surveying the region for undiscovered resources and good spots to build new settlements. This of course is not the first-time people have attempted to settle the Icewood—the previous attempt in the eighth century was wiped out by boneclaw wyverns raised from the dead by Lady Illmarrow. Recently, an enormous Khyber shard known as the Madstone has begun to call people to it, transfiguring them into gibbering servants. Other, as yet undiscovered horrors might lurk in the woods—the Forest Queen is rumored to take on a harsh and exacting persona within the weald.

BONECLAW WYVERN

Large Undead, Unaligned

Armor Class 13 (natural armor)

Hit Points 136 (16d10+48)

Speed 20 ft., fly 80 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
19 (+4)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	5 (-3)	12 (+1)	6 (-2)

Skills Perception +7

Damage Resistances cold, necrotic

Damage Immunities poison

Condition Immunities Exhaustion, Poisoned

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 17

Languages --

Challenge 8 (2,300 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +3

Unusual Nature. The boneclaw wyvern doesn't need air, food, drink, or sleep.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The boneclaw wyvern makes two attacks: one with its bite and one with its stinger. While flying, it can use its claws in place of one other attack.

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one creature. Hit: 14 (3d6 + 4) piercing damage.

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 17 (3d8 + 4) slashing damage.

Stinger. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one creature. Hit: 11 (2d6 + 4) piercing damage. The target must make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw, taking 14 (4d6) cold and 14 (4d6) poison damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

THE MAMONT TUNDRA

Harsh conditions prohibit extended settlements in the Mamont Tundra, a vast expanse occupying north-central Karnath. In addition to the signature wooly mammoths, the wildlife of the Mamont Tundra includes other large herbivores like wooly rhinos, mid-size predators like wolves, and of course smaller creatures like rabbits.

The most populous group of humanoids within the Mamont Tundra are the Tuskul goliaths, but several other groups with slightly different practices and made up of different ancestries also live here. Hunkering down for winter and migrating in the warmer months, these peoples have existed as a separate polity from the rest of Karnath for thousands of years.

The peoples of the tundra generally follow what Galifaran scholars would identify as “primal practices”, with faiths that identify *many* spirits rather than just the nine and six of the Sovereign Host. In addition to serving as healers and spiritual guides, the shamans of these groups also practice a form of artifice powered by primal magic. During the cold winter months primal magic maintains furnaces, with the excess heat carefully maintained and spread throughout the large communal home. Rather than the extractive mining techniques used in the rest of Karnath, tribes acquire ore and other precious resources by bargaining with primal spirits.

The peoples of the Mamont Tundra lived in relative isolation from the pre-Galifaran period until King Jarot’s lightning rail project in the 9th century. At that point, Galifaran surveyors, aided by House Tharashk, realized the incredible wealth of resources lying just below the surface of the tundra. This focus on the area also buoyed interest in mammoth wool, leading to a continent-wide craze in the 860s. Supply simply could not keep up, leading both to horrific violence enacted against the native groups and a proliferation of charlatans selling fake mammoth wool clothing. The eventual failure of the lightning rail project in the 870s and the withdrawal of widespread interest did not undo the damage that had been done, especially by missionaries of the Sovereign Host. Failed mines and other structures still litter the tundra’s landscape, a reminder of Galifaran imperialism.

TERYK

Seated behind several natural barriers but on a convenient road connecting western and eastern Karnath, Teryk has changed hands several times throughout Karnath’s history. Despite this, the ir’Teryk family has long ruled Teryk County, asserting independent control of the area despite lacking the national authority that being a proper duchy would provide. For now, Teryk remains nominally a part of Lyodnica even if it lacks a proper connection to the capital of the duchy, Ice.

Banking. Teryk has leveraged its in-the-middle position to become a minor financial hub. These relationships, even if not directly with the ir’Teryk family, have kept the town both relevant and independent. Count Halden ir’Teryk is a member of the Aurum’s platinum concord and secretly a member of the Shadow Cabinet, using his connections and personal wealth to conceal the ill-gotten gains of his fellow conspirators. As such, Teryk has become a holding place for some of the most valuable art pieces in Khorvaire, priceless cultural artifacts protected by some of the best security gold can buy.



NARATH

Positioned on the northwest corner of Karnath at the mouth of Scions Sound, Narath is covered by chilly tundra. The city that gave the duchy its name was sacked by Aundair in 989, a devastating blow that the duchy has still not recovered from. Most of the duchy’s population lives along its northern coast, dependent on the rich bounty of the Bitter Sea in the summer.

HISTORY

The oldest human settlements in Karnath lie along its northern coast, as sailors from Lhazaar (whether intentionally or unintentionally) ventured west of the Hoarfrost Mountains. The imposing expanse of the Karnnwood isolated it from the kingdoms to the south, leaving Narath out of most of Karnn the Conqueror’s warmongering. This also led to Narath becoming a sort of refuge for marginalized people; while the land is harsh, respect was earned through deeds rather than ties of ancestry or family. Karnn’s expansionism did eventually bring Narath into the fold, but with the recognition that any campaign to conquer the northern coast would be extremely costly for both sides.

Originally a disparate collective of northern fishing towns, Narath only began to evolve after Galifar I’s son, Karnn, began to create structure throughout the land he governed. The largest port town, Narath, was elevated to the seat of a new duchy under the rulership of the newly minted ir’Tanar family. These moves set the stage for the Galifar-Lhazaar war that began in 28 YK; the shipyards of Narath were infused with money so they could construct and repair the warships Galifar needed to force the Lhazaar princes to heel.

Under the Kingdom of Galifar, improvements in arcane science made life in Narath both more comfortable and more profitable. Fishing moved from being primarily for

sustenance to primarily commercial, as ships brought back more fish each summer, and those fish could more easily and safely be transported to distant markets or preserved for other parts of the year. Agriculture still struggled, as effects like *plant growth* are a blind spot for arcane magic and dragonmarks.

Prior to his death and the onset of the Last War, King Jarot bolstered the armadas of both Aundair and Karnath, fearing some unknown terror might strike from the Frostfell across the Bitter Sea. These renewed navies were immediately utilized by their princes, with Karn I and Wrogar contesting each other in the resource-rich waters. The docks of the city of Narath held the largest of Karnath's northern shipyards, constantly processing lumber brought up from the Karnwood and turning it into new and improved warships.

The city of Narath was besieged several times during the war, but it was in 989 YK that Aundair successfully landed assault forces and razed the city. The Burning of Narath may not be the most iconic of the war's disasters—Karnath's razing of Shadukar earlier that year was far fouler and occurred to a more populous city—but it nonetheless stained the continent in blood. Arcane fire from Aundair spread rapidly through the wooden houses of the city, indiscriminately burning military and civilian infrastructure alike. The magically enhanced fire rapidly outpaced people's ability to flee the city, leading to tens of thousands of civilian deaths.

In the near decade since the Burning of Narath, commercial activity in the Bitter Sea has recovered but the city has not. The city's Fernian manifest zone tore open on the Day of Mourning, allowing salamanders to spill through and decimate reconstruction efforts. Karnathi scholars blame the Aundairian war magic for weakening the ethereal veil that separated the city from the plane of fire, but whatever the cause the port is currently unusable.

GOVERNANCE

Warlord Renn ir'Tanar (human he/him) is as bitter as the sea he gazes upon every day from his ancestral family castle. He has not moved on from the devastation wrought by Aundair and sees Kaius III's willingness to sign a treaty as cowardice. However, his daughter Mordalyn disagreed with his subtle and prolonged plan to undermine the king, instead joining up with Drago Thul to directly challenge Kaius. She now lives in tropical Stormreach supporting Drago's dissent, far away from the duchy that was once her birthright. Renn believes both that she is foolish and that she will ultimately rejoin him; for now, his founding role in At All Costs is the primary way by which he seeks to obtain his grand political goals.

CULTURAL HALLMARKS

Born of the Sea. The people of Narath are the finest sailors in Karnath, whether they are out on the waters for commercial or military purposes. Almost every job there is either at sea or in support of those who are. Unlike the Lhazaarites to the east, the people of Narath find solidarity in being part of a united kingdom; the people of the eastern coast are too chaotic and vainglorious to appreciate what it means to work together towards something greater.

Bitter Hearts. The people of Narath are isolated from most of Khorvaire, leaving them to solely dwell on their

conflict with Aundair. Grudges are not easy to forgive in the frozen north, and their reasons for grudges against Aundair are numerous.

TAER SYRAEN, THE WINTER CITADEL

The Prince of Frost rules his feyspire just north of the ducal border between Narath and Korth. Once the Prince of Summer, his heart froze when his betrothed abandoned him and thus her courtly responsibilities for a mortal hero. He vowed to bring her back and force her to love him, so she cast her and her new lover forward in time, hoping that when they reincarnate Shan Syraen's heart would have thawed. Now he forever torments valiant heroes, hoping that in doing so he might once again find his lost love.

It's unknown if the fey of the Winter Citadel reflect the martial inclinations of the people of Karnath, or if its innate martial nature influenced the nation's people. Either way, the latest conflict began when Count Rolund ir'Tanar (cousin to Warlord Renn ir'Tanar) investigated reports of marauders attacking travelers on the road along the Scions Sound in the fall of 997. Instead of haggard bandits, the company of soldiers found a fortress made of ice guarded by winter eladrin; further investigation was rebuffed by howling winter winds.

Thus far, the count has chosen to conceal this threat from his cousin, hoping the spring thaw of 998 will afford new opportunities to investigate and confront the forces that gather within his borders. While the Winter Citadel is known in the region, this knowledge is largely in the form of myths and legends rather than actionable intelligence; it's been centuries since Shan Syraen made his presence known.

The forces of the Prince of Frost are divided up into four groups. The Hail are the brutal knights who ride out in the name of their lord. The Ice are the artisans and wizards, archivists, and architects who preserve the fortress and its history. The Sleet are the lord's spies and tricksters, chiefly searching for word that the Prince's former love has returned to the world. Lastly are the Snow, whose creative pursuits are always unique but never last, like a snowflake.

Plenty of mortals would entreat the Prince of Frost in hope of gaining power. One such group sought Taer Syraen out centuries ago; Nyria Thuranni d'Phiarlan (elf she/her) led a troupe of shadow-marked elves into the Karnwood in search of the Winter Citadel. They succeeded but were caught and imprisoned, eventually bargaining for limited freedom in exchange for service. Known as the faeryvar, "children of summer," by the eladrin of the citadel, they have fully integrated within Shan Syraen's knightly structure. Of all the residents of Taer Syraen, the faeryvar are the most likely to be found far from its icy walls, acting as the prince's eyes and ears in the mortal world. Their immediate commander remains Nyria, her already long life extended by fey magic.

The wise remember that while Taer Syraen is an important influence in northwestern Karnath, it's not the only source of winter spirits. The chilly powers of the Prince could be mistaken for the ruthless machinations of the Overlord Dral Khatuur, whose influence in the bitter sea waxes and wanes. Alternatively, the icy spirits of Risia can act with a similar malevolence, locking their subjects

in eternal stasis. Would-be heroes have been felled by mistaking one freezing influence for another.

THE CITY OF NARATH

The surviving citizenry of Narath, a city still in ruins, has dispersed among the outlying areas and coastal towns. The city itself is not entirely abandoned, however, as the salamanders occupying the city's downtown are unable to venture far from the portal that brought them to the material plane; the outlying parts of the city were also less ravaged by the Aundairian assault, leaving them somewhat livable.

THE INFERNAL RIFT

An imposing tear in the very fabric of reality, this rift stands at the heart of a Fernian manifest zone covering the entire downtown and harbor area. While the chilly waters of the Bitter Sea could freeze as far south as the Karnathi coast on particularly cold winters, the downtown and harbor of Narath were always protected from the cold (As per the Deadly Heat property in *Exploring Eberron*, all creatures gain resistance to cold damage, and a creature that is usually resistant to cold damage becomes immune.)

Now, the area is a beachhead for salamanders who slither among the scorched ruins in the heart of the city. These salamanders are not under the thumb of any efreet but represent a free group led by a noble whose Ignan name roughly translates to Brightlance (salamander they/them). Driven by a desire to escape from the contained servitude of the efreeti as well as the Fernian impulse to build, the salamanders have plundered every piece of metal they can find within the manifest zone to build shelter and maintain their arsenal. Brightlance's forces maintain their militaristic posture on both sides of the portal, as concerned with an assault by efreeti forces as they are by mortals. Salamanders do need to eat, and a lack of suitable food on the material side of the portal forces Brightlance to rely on resupply from Fernia.

When Fernia is remote (which occurs at least once every five years during the month of Zarantyr but can happen other times at shorter and less predictable intervals), the rift closes. The salamanders have to stockpile for and scavenge during this time, as not only are they cut off from resupply, but their fires burn less bright—their features and attacks only do half as much fire damage while Fernia is remote.

CASTLE NARATH

An imposing structure on the western edge of the city, the damage to Castle Narath has largely been repaired. From here, Warlord ir'Tanar plots to take the harbor back from Brightlance; the last time Fernia was remote was before the Treaty of Thronehold, when forces were simply not available to confront the salamanders. Now, he plans to take advantage of the upcoming rift closure and the fading of the manifest zone to defeat the salamanders and permanently close the portal to Fernia.



VASFOLD

Covering Karnath's southeastern expanse, Vasdfold is a bridge to the Mror Holds as well as the primary platform for any future Karnathi attempt to invade and conquer the mountain clans. Two major towns sit on the shores of Lake Dark, with Lakeside serving as the capital while Irontown is more business oriented. The soils of Vasdfold are not quite as generous as Vulyar to the southwest, but they're still capable of supporting a large number of scattered rural communities.

HISTORY

This far eastern expanse is littered with the remains of the goblin-dwarven conflict from the days of old. While the Dhakaani ruins only protrude minimally from the surface, their roots extend down into Khyber; in the millennia since the conflict, most of these passageways have collapsed, but when they open it can spell trouble for anyone who lives nearby.

Of all the regions that Karnn conquered to forge Karnath, Vasdfold was the least unified; the towns of the region were fiercely independent and did not join arms to resist Karnn's army. The creation of the duchy gave the region a new identity, one very different from the distant capital of Korth; even the very weather was opposite, as while Korth is cold and wet the grasslands of Vasdfold are warm and dry. The sheer distance meant that Vasdfold was largely left to its own devices so long as taxes and tribute continued to flow west; it was only when a Karnathi king developed imperial ambitions over the rest of the continent that Vasdfold recognized the outside world.

The success of Galifar and the subsequent ambition of his son to conquer the Mror Holds was the first time in a thousand years that Vasdfold was seriously forced to reckon with the outside world. Soldiers and support staff from across the continent flowed into Irontown, marshaled to

lay siege to the reclusive dwarves. The sudden shock of exposure hardened the distinct identity of the people of Vasfold, especially as their beloved duke, Sigismund ir'Tanar, pushed on Prince Karrn to recompense the people for the damages wrought by the war.

With the success of the campaign, Karrn chose to appoint a new duke of Vasfold who would be loyal to Korth while managing the flow of tribute from the freshly conquered Mror Holds. The displacement of the ir'Tanar family was deeply unpopular and further entrenched the sense of independent identity among the people of Vasfold.

Unfortunately, despite their desire for independence from Korth, Vasfold never succeeded. In the over eight hundred years between the conquering of the Mror Holds and the death of King Jarot, Korth put down seven uprisings for independence, although three of these successfully displaced the warlord and forced the crown to appoint a new family to fill their place. The reasons for any individual failure were numerous, but the open plains made it easy for an army to sweep in and crush rebellion.

Economically, the addition of the lightning rail from Krona Peak was an enormous boon to Vasfold. Irontown was established and, both responding to and promoting the rest of Khorvaire's hunger for metal in everyday life, quickly grew into a major industrial town focused on processing the raw ore shipped in from the mountains. Cannith inventors partnered with dwarven smiths to create industrial forges, beginning the process of mass production that would define Jarot's reign and the coming conflict.

The advent of the Last War was hard for the people of Vasfold due to both the successful Mroran independence movement and the plagues and famines that led Kaius I to make the Blood of Vol the state religion. Vasfold largely rejected the religious shift, and resentment festered when Kaius raised taxes to compensate for the famines in the west. The first failed campaign to recapture the Mror Holds triggered another unsuccessful rebellion by the people of Vasfold, adding to Karrnath's military deployment difficulties by splitting attention between the war and internal suppression. When King Jaron assumed the crown in 961 YK, he reduced internal suppression, increased draft requirements, and played to nationalistic sentiments that Aundair and Cyre were far worse, a strategy that largely worked to stabilize the region.

Unfortunately, Vasfold has not experienced a post-war peace like most of the other duchies. Raids from Valenar warbands agitate the deployed Karrnathi forces, hoping to bait them into escalation. At the same time, renewed international trade brings wealth to the region but doesn't distribute it equitably. The duchy is politically unstable and its collapse could be the tipping point for several other brewing crisis within the nation.

GOVERNANCE

Falko ir'Jaranus (human he/him) is the current Duke of Vasfold, but his family has only held the title for two generations; his mother Forsindh allied with the Karrnathi crown during the uprising of 957, earning a promotion from Countess to Duchess. He's currently looking to secure a political marriage for his eldest child, Oydelis (human they/them), a choice that will likely decide the future of the duchy. On one hand, a marriage to a prominent family from Korth could secure the favor of the crown; on the

other, a marriage to a prominent Mroran family could secure future business relations as well as provide a backstop if the duke tried to defect from Karrnath.

For their part, Oydelis has grown up more focused on military success than relationships and is deeply uncomfortable at the prospect of having a partner at all; even a political marriage arranged for them would be an unwanted intrusion. Their younger siblings, Fraedus (human he/him) and Bauin (human she/her) are still a few years away from participating in noble courting rituals and not yet candidates for a political marriage like Oydelis, even if they were to abdicate their claim to the title.

CULTURAL HALLMARKS

Failed Independence. Vasfold has repeatedly struggled to assert the independence its residents believe it deserves. The actual reasons for its persistence and failure are complicated and contested by historians, but the general sense is that its distance from the capital generates resentment but its open fields and connection to the resource rich Mror Holds make it important enough to the crown that it never actually breaks away.

Vassals. Few elves made their way this far inland during the early days of Karrnath, and Seekers were less necessary to manage the effects of Mabaran manifest zones, as they were much rarer in Vasfold than in its southwestern neighbor, Vulyar. While the beliefs of the halflings and dwarves that immigrated to Vasfold over the years may not have exactly matched the Pyrenean Creed that humans brought from Sarlona, there's a general agreement on the shape and structure of divinity. The people of the duchy resisted the state institution of the Blood of Vol by ignoring it, continuing to worship the Sovereign Host. Various carrots and sticks failed to change this reality in the 80 years the Blood of Vol was the state religion.

Cultural Mixing. Situated at the foot of the Mror Holds and the northern edge of the Talenta Plains, Vasfold has a wider diversity of ancestries than the rest of Karrnath. Literal *small towns* aren't just rural and sparse in population but are communities that are literally built smaller than anything you would find in the west—5' tall door frames are more than enough for a halfling or dwarf and the lower ceilings are a practical way to save on construction costs.

FORT DEEPDARK

Countess Asta ir'Vanalan, the Shield of Tamend, (halfling she/her) defends Tamend County (about a fifth of the Talenta border) from Valenar raiders. The Vanalan family was only recently ennobled in 995 YK, recognizing Asta's military prowess and filling the vacancy left by the ir'Jennrei line when its last eligible scion was slain on the Day of Mourning on a military excursion into Cyre. The Shield of Tamend is firmly aligned with the Karrnathi crown and hopes to promote stronger ties between Vasfold and the western cities.

Viscount Brandin ir'Dulinch (dwarf they/them) manages the day-to-day operations of the fort and its immediate surroundings. The garrison remains under strict orders to minimize and control engagements with any trespassing elves, but the viscount chafes at the crown's restrictions; they would prefer to directly confront the elven raiders, thinking this would put an end to the assaults.

Countess Valan has opened much of the land for sale in response to the depletion of farmers from the region, both from emigration and the attrition of those slain by raiders, hoping to return the fields to providing food for the nation filling her tax coffers. Even foreigners are eligible to purchase stakes, although they must be neither Cyran nor an elf from Valenar and they must swear fealty and thus citizenship to the nation of Karrnath.

LAKE DARK

The largest body of fresh water within the nation, Lake Dark is glacially fed from the Mror Holds. While the upper reaches of the water—where people boat, fish, and swim—are perfectly ordinary, the depths contain a manifest zone connected to Dolurrh. Local criminals know better than to hide bodies in the lake bottom, as those who die an unjust death will almost certainly return as a revenant if their bodies enter the manifest zone. The lake is deep enough that little light penetrates the depths, and divination magic has failed to provide a definitive answer to what lies at the bottom of the lake and rumors abound. Roll or choose from the Lake Bottom Rumors table for local color.

LAKE BOTTOM RUMORS

d4 At the bottom of Lake Dark lies...

- 1 An ancient tomb dedicated to a champion of the Queen of the Dead. Any who brave its traps and undead defenders can claim the powerful artifacts that lie within.
- 2 A devastating monster bound to eternal slumber through the ennui of Dolurrh. A ritual to awaken the beast requires a convergence of the moons to break its chains.
- 3 A secret base run by the dragons of Argonnessen.
- 4 Ships made by the “Forgotten People,” proof of the conspiracy that humans predated goblins in Khorvaire.
- 5 A secretive Cannith East base building a ship powered by ghosts that will be able to explore the Ring of Siberys.
- 6 Relics from Khorvaire’s mysterious past in the Age of Giants

IRONTOWN

Count Jakab ir’Jakab governs the business friendly Irontown. A dense, dirty industrial settlement filled with refineries, few stop in the town for leisure. Here, lumber from the western forests meets iron from the Mror Holds to create steel that is exported for use in all forms of modern conveniences.

CANNITH EAST

Since its founding, Irontown has had deep ties to House Cannith. House Cannith’s Fabricator’s Guild joined forces with Soranath smiths to innovate on steel production, leveraging a minor Fernian manifest zone to build the first structures of what would become Irontown. Viceroy Boros d’Cannith is the current head of production in the region and has garnered a reputation for a callous approach to worker safety.

While House Cannith technicians own the intellectual property rights to the refining processes used within Irontown and manufacture the arcane forges used by the refineries, the house directly owns very few of the refineries, which are instead owned and operated by private individuals.

AURUM CLUBHOUSE

While the city of Lakeside is the preferred holiday destination in the region, the Aurum Clubhouse in Irontown remains a central meeting point for the affluent to hobnob. Despite its proximity to the Mror Holds, the Irontown chapter has no connections to the Platinum Concord; the highest-ranking member is Beatrix Mezei, a gold concordian with a controlling stake in a plurality of the town’s refining operations.

THE RED TROUT

A revolutionary hotbed, the Red Trout features live entertainment from the greatest fiddlers in the nation not tied to the performing crucibles of House Thuranni. Working class writers trade manifestos decrying the state of the nation, envisioning a better future for the people of Vasfold. For now, authorities believe the tavern to be harmless—full of blowhards who are all talk and no action. This belief persists despite the tavern’s historic ties to several of Vasfold’s (failed) revolutions, including the 957 uprising that elevated the ir’Jaranus family. Ezster Dobos (dwarf she/her) is a particularly influential writer whose intersectional works have gained distribution even beyond the borders of Karrnath.

LAKESIDE

The seat of the duchy lies in Lakeside, a popular resort location within the nation. The town is surrounded by idyllic farm country. Although Aundairian saboteurs destroyed the irrigation system in 993 YK; wine production has only just resumed for the 998 vintages.

THE PLATINUM DRAGON

A premium resort with a five-story hotel, the Platinum Dragon in Lakeside is one of several locations in Khorvaire for House Ghallanda’s premium hospitality experience. While Karrnath’s well-to-do maintained secondary residences in the town, the rise of a middle class over the last two centuries led House Ghallanda to build services to accommodate the nouveau riche who profited off the post-lightning rail mercantile boom as well as the war itself.

THE MARINA

Between luxury boats and fishing operations, most residents of Lakeside have a tie to aquatic operations. Harbormaster Erik Kozma (dwarf he/him) is an affable elderly dwarf on the exterior but has secret ties to the Order of the Emerald Claw. He keeps a close eye on anything unusual brought onto the docks, especially if it might provide insight into the mystery of the lake bottom.

TEMPLE OF THE SOVEREIGN HOST

Lakeside’s Temple of the Sovereign Host features a large statue of Aureon the Lawbringer, depicting him as an elderly human man in traditional wizarding robes holding both a quarterstaff and an open tome. The duchy’s well-to-do sit in a segregated section for services; this provides a critical influence network between peers as well as an opportunity for lower nobility to connect with higher nobility. Patrik Mezei leads the congregation, a silver concordian with business interests within both Lakeside and Irontown.



VEDYKAR

A small duchy that shares a border with five others, Vedykar bridges the divide between eastern and western Karnath. The eastern half of the duchy is occupied by the Shadowmount Forest, while the western half consists of the city of Vedykar and rural farming communities enjoying the resource-rich soils south of the Ashen Spires.

HISTORY

Built atop Dhakaani ruins, the goblin city of Vedykar fell during the human expansion eastward prior to the rise of Karn. Its new inhabitants quickly established themselves as one of the many petty kingdoms that littered the region, benefitting from the city's high quality civic engineering.

When Karn pushed southwards into halfling lands, many of the tribes chose to ally with the nascent empire rather than resist. The Jorasco clan was immediately granted special status and invited into the heart of the empire as Karn recognized the value the healing halflings could bring. The clan's matriarch, drawn by primal spirits, the draconic prophecy, or some other force, resettled her people in Vedykar and established Resthold.

In the interim period between Karn and the War of the Mark, an intellectually inclined warlord established the University of Vedykar. In conjunction with the university, House Jorasco founded the Healer's Guild to conduct medical research in addition to practicing life-saving arts.

Jorasco's compliance with the War of the Mark made Vedykar, like Karrlakton, one of the first places in the Five Nations to round up and execute aberrant marked individuals. Before the Twelve were firmly established in Korth, House Jorasco often played host for the assembled dragonmarked houses in the city of Vedykar.

The founding of the Kingdom of Galifar changed little for the people of Vedykar, as the duchy was well-accustomed to being an accessory to empires. Neither the

heart of empire nor a fringe province, Vedykar prospered from trade. Jarot's plans for lightning rails reaffirmed Vedykar's position as the crossroads of Karnath, with the major east-west lines pathing through the city. The quickening of continental trade dramatically increased demand for *orbs of time*, a common magic item invented in Vedykar that is similar to a pocket watch; the finest timepieces are known to come from the duchy's magewrights.

Unlike the western duchies, Vedykar avoided the worst of the war's damages. With only a small sliver of land along the Cyre River, few armies trampled its fields of grain. Furthermore, the location of Resthold and importance of House Jorasco made the Cyran military wary of trying to disrupt Karnath's supply lines by way of besieging the city. This is not to say the people of Vedykar were without loss, as they shipped adults off to war just like anyone else, but those who stayed home were never really forced to confront the horrors of the conflict in that immediate and personal sense.

GOVERNANCE

Warlord Nils ir'Käser (human they/them) rules over Vedykar in a more detached and distant fashion than their peers. They never took to the field of battle themselves, delegating such responsibilities to their military advisor, the now-exiled General Drago Thul. In his place Nils has appointed General Giulia Kindlimann (human she/her), who's been trying to break the Vedykar force's loyalty to Drago.

Nils maintains an extensive rare book collection and has maintained the ir'Käser investments in the University of Vedykar, where their brother is the dean. His most recent interests have been in ancient Giant texts, a situation complicated by Drago's flight to Stormreach.

CULTURAL HALLMARKS

The Adamant Fang. Based out of Shadowmount Forest, the Adamant Fang is an elite force of light cavalry that gained renown for its successful guerilla operations against Aundair in the Rekkenwood. In addition to horses, the company uses dire wolverines as mounts—while not as swift, the ferocity of the wolverines makes them an enormous asset in combat.

Commerce. While the city of Vedykar lacks the industrial capacity of the western cities, it makes up for it with its exchanges that facilitate trade between eastern and western Karnath. The worship of Kol Korran is popular throughout Vedykar and even has a strong presence in the rural farmlands. This position has allowed local banks to spring up in competition with the Mror lords and House Kundarak, cementing the city's position as a financial hub.

Multiculturalism. Nearly one in four residents of Vedykar is a dwarf and one in five is a halfling, substantially higher numbers than the rest of the nation. Halfling and dwarven immigrants have preserved their mother tongues despite centuries of human rule; trade occurs primarily in Common, but most people are conversant in multiple languages and merchants have signage in all three languages.

SHADOWMOUNT FOREST

Despite its ominous name, which actually comes from simply being in the shadow of the Ashen Spires, the people of Vedykar have an amicable relationship with the Shadowmount Forest. The Forest Queen's presence is strong in these woods, but those who respect her tenets have little trouble with its fey. Unfortunately, the new push for industrialization in Western Karnath has begun to influence the wealthier members of Vedykar society. Some of them have begun looking to the Shadowmount Forest as a source for lumber to fuel their dreams of belching smoke and consuming fire to feed the maw of industry, finding it preferable to the dangerous (and crown-owned) Nightwood.

THE CITY OF VEDYKAR

Exempt from the ravages of war, Vedykar's ancient infrastructure is remarkably functional—a testament to Dhakaani engineering. Accommodations once made for goblins are now used by the city's halflings.

CATHEDRAL OF THE SILVER FLAME

While the vast majority of its residents identify as Vassals—the Blood of Vol never really caught on here, despite the proximity of Atur—Vedykar is home to the largest congregation of Flamists in the nation. Lady Offejjaia (human she/her) leads the congregation here in addition to being a powerful cleric and high-ranking member of the Order of Knights Templar. This position has brought her into conflict with her immediate superior, the Thranish Cardinal Baerdren Davik (human he/him). While Thrane's theocracy blurred the lines between church and state, Lady Offejjaia remained loyal to Karnath and her mission of protecting the innocent from supernatural evil.

THE FIST OF MABAR

The dark side of Vedykar's commercial interests is its profitability for organized crime. Known as the Fist of Mabar, this criminal organization is embedded into Vedykar's high society. Their vices of choice are running a protection racket and smuggling all sorts of goods, ranging from legal goods "skipping" tariffs to theft and black market sale of military equipment. The organization's leader, Heda Stettler (elf she/her) has maintained her position for over a hundred years and personally knows many other crime bosses across the continent (like Saidan Boromar of Sharn). Heda is a powerful necromancer who has secretly pledged herself to the service of the Queen of All Tears, ruler of the Last Desert in Mabar.

RESTHOLD

The headquarters for House Jorasco, Resthold is a separate walled community within the city that has radically different architecture that treats the small stature of halflings as the default. In addition to top-of-the-line medical facilities, Resthold operates teaching facilities for the Healer's Guild—while treatment at the former is pricey, services at the latter are steeply discounted and provide care for the majority of the city.

Baron Ulara d'Jorasco runs the dragonmarked house from her villa; she spends most of her day in meetings before retiring to her private library to study. She rarely travels for business meetings, preferring to send

DIRE WOLVERINE

Large Beast, Unaligned

Armor Class 15 (natural armor)

Hit Points 42 (5d10+15)

Speed 30 ft., climb 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	17 (+3)	17 (+3)	3 (-4)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)

Skills Athletics +5, Perception +3

Senses passive Perception 13

Languages --

Challenge 2 (2,300 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +2

ACTIONS

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 12 (2d8 + 3) piercing damage.

REACTIONS

Rage (Recharges after a Short or Long Rest). When the dire wolverine takes damage, as a reaction it can fly into a rage. While raging it has advantage on attack rolls and resistance to bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage, but attack rolls against it have advantage. The rage lasts until the dire wolverine ends its turn without making an attack.

intermediaries in her place. The one thing that gets her outside the walls of Resthold are outbreaks of disease, to apply both her extensive training in treatment and her decades of public health management expertise.

Perhaps the most remarkable feature of Resthold is a small, magical lake. Those who bathe in the lake at dawn become almost totally amnesiac; the waters wipe away memories but leave basic skills. Demand has increased enormously since the end of the war and the lifting of most travel restrictions. While induced amnesia is an extreme measure, it's a mental health service that is uniquely available at Resthold and can be an appealing alternative for those who struggle to live with the shame, guilt, or other trauma of their past.

THE UNIVERSITY OF VEDYKAR

An elite, exclusive institution, the University of Vedykar is home to premier scholars on a wide variety of topics. While the school is nominally dedicated to Aureon, it is not a school of magic; prospective wizards are better off with the Twelve for education in arcane science. The school's biological studies are second to none, and its philosophers, historians, and mathematicians are well respected throughout the continent. Its language arts department is noticeably smaller than that of comparable schools like the University of Fairhaven or the University of Korth, but its dwarven studies in particular are of higher quality than either of its competitors.

Dean Lorian ir'Käser, the Duke's younger brother, is the latest in a long line of deans that sees access to the university as reserved for Karnath's upper crust. Steep tuition fees aren't the only barrier to entry—a requirement of two letters of recommendation from recognized nobility make it difficult for anyone to attend unless their family is on good terms with existing members of Karnath's nobility.



VULYAR

The lands of Vulyar, the southernmost Karnathi duchy, have more in common with the Talenta Plains than they do the rest of Karnath. Vulyar's population is spread out among grassland farming communities, where nutrient-rich soils attempt to support the rest of the nation. The duchy's border with the Talenta Plains is mostly artificial, although one could attempt to differentiate between southern Karnath and the northern Talenta Plains by the types of manifest zones that are common; the plains have connections primarily to Dolurrah and Thelanis, while Vulyar has primarily Mabaran manifest zones, the most famous of which lies in the county of Odakyr.

HISTORY

Prior to the arrival of humanity, the duchy of Vulyar was simply the northern edge of halfling habitation in Khorvaire. Scattered goblinoid communities dotted the landscape but remained separate from the nomadic patterns of the halfling tribes; no known archaeological evidence suggests the two groups intermingled. The expansion of humanity east of Scions Sound disrupted these communities, until eventually Karnn butchered the goblinoids and drove them out of Karnath entirely. While the halflings were not subject to the same genocidal campaign as the goblins, they were nonetheless forced south by the encroaching human kingdoms.

Human habitation has always been contingent on the viability of sedentary agriculture; communities that push too far south would eventually disband in the face of the arid plains that cannot support their lifestyle. Throughout the years some individuals have joined with the halflings, but halflings far more commonly abandoned the nomadic ways of the plains for the material wealth promised by Karnath, either as mercenaries for the fledgling House Deneith or through the houses Ghallanda and Jorasco.

Shortly after Galifar I's reign over the continent began, the Talenta Plains were formally included in the Kingdom of Galifar. The duchy of Vulyar was made responsible for collecting taxes and tribute of the nomadic halflings, who had no fixed towns to govern. This arrangement worked well enough, as the halfling tribes carefully concealed their wealth to avoid the avaricious gaze of empire, revealing just enough to remove suspicion. The settlements of Vulyar remained as they always had, scattered agrarian communities living in the 'good enough' soils south of Vedykar.

The Last War transformed Vulyar; not only did the tribute of the halfling tribes dry up, but the long border along the Cyre River became a key point of contention. Many battles were fought in the duchy, as the Karnathi military pushed into Cyre or was pushed back. The halfling tribes cut deals with Cyre, Karnath, and later the elves of Valenar, pledging their support in both trade and politics.

Today, the elves of Valenar are the duchy's chief concern, even more than its long border with the Mournland. Constant raids by Valaes Tairn warbands disrupt attempts to rebuild in the wake of the war, but these raids are more intended to draw out a military response than about doing lasting damage.

GOVERNANCE

First Warlord Gruden ir'Erdei (human he/him) governs Vulyar; his prestigious title was earned through his dedication and service to the crown. The former chancellor of Rekkenmark, he stepped into his current position after his older sister was slain on the field of battle and left behind no heirs. Unlike the western warlords who anticipate conflict with Aundair, the First Warlord is actively engaged in conflict with the elves of Valenar. He feels boxed in by Kaius III's restraint, convinced that were he permitted, he could lead a force down south and force the elves to stop their brazen assaults on Karnath. His concerns about war are not some yearnings for glory but a deep sense that a true war with Valenar is inevitable, and he'd rather begin that now before the elves can reclaim more of their ancient artifacts and defenses.

CULTURAL HALLMARKS

Axebeaks. Nearly as swift as horses, axebeaks have roamed the grasslands of Vulyar since before humanity's arrival. While wild axebeaks are vicious and territorial, the duchy's domesticated birds are like any other mount outside of combat. Inside combat, axebeaks fitted for war let loose, leveraging their wedge-like beaks to lethal effect. Axebeak cavalry were a critical component of Karnath's military efforts in the south, with their superior agility and resilience allowing them to pose a threat independent from their rider.

Conquering Fist. An elite force of horse-riding heavy cavalry, the Conquering Fist recruited veterans from the frontlines and promised them glory and riches in exchange for continued service. The organization's lackadaisical approach to chivalric standards and more open terms of enrollment blurs the line between mercenary company and knightly order, even if members did pledge to exclusively serve Karnath rather than simply the highest bidder. Recently King Kaius III has made entreaties to the order's leadership to get them to move their headquarters to Korth; the king seems to believe that the broad

backgrounds of the order's membership make them exemplars of the Karnath he wishes to build. The First Warlord is concerned in turn that this will hamper his military readiness for Valenar assaults.

Seeker Rituals. As humanity explored what is now Southern Karnath, they found hostile Mabaran manifest zones. The rituals brought by the elves formerly aligned with the Mark of Death provided methods for living alongside these manifest zones, harnessing and repurposing their power and mitigating the plane's hostility to life. The onset of the war disrupted these practices, either through deployments carrying people far away from home or simply through overly zealous Vassal lords. The installation of the Blood of Vol as the state religion brought focus and attention back to these discarded rituals, allowing the land to bear life-giving food once again for the rest of the nation. Today, rituals to diffuse the effects of Mabaran manifest zones are well understood and regularly maintained despite the Blood of Vol no longer being the state religion.

FORT BONES AND FORT ZOMBIE

The County of Odakyr is the southernmost county in Karnath, and it contains both Fort Bones and Fort Zombie. Outside of Atur it has the most potent Mabaran manifest zones in the nation, these were exploited by Malevenor, while he was still alive, to refine the necromantic rituals now known as the Odakyr Rites.

Fort Zombie. Formerly known as Fort Szarrog, Fort Zombie was built atop goblinoid foundations from before humanity's arrival on the continent. During King Jarot's reign, Fort Szarrog grew in importance through its position on the lightning rail line between Vedykar and Gatherhold, with the surrounding town and farms enjoying the riches brought by trade. Prior to the war breaking out, Prince Kaius bulked up the military presence at this inland fort, a move that drew little attention at the time but was a clear intimation of the conspiracy to contest Mishann's coronation. The fort continued to serve an important role throughout the war as the central command for Karnath's assaults against Metrol. The outlying farms were destroyed by the ceaseless machine of war, but since the war's end the crown has begun to support efforts to repurpose the land towards food production.

Fort Bones. Once the seat of the county, the town of Orozlsom was—like Fort Zombie—transformed into a critical military base. Gyrnar ir'Shult, the Shield of Odakyr, abactor of the Blood of Vol, and co-creator of the Odakyr Rites, was sidelined by Warlord Kaina ir'Durna at the onset of the war. Warlord Kaina took charge of the southern offensive, but he was a dedicated Vassal who failed to respect Seeker rituals. This was disastrous, causing a surge in Mabaran energies that spread plague and famine throughout the Karnathi forces and stalled out early attempts to assault Metrol. When the Blood of Vol was instated as the state religion, Gyrnar ir'Shult was returned to his post; the keep and the center of the now-abandoned town was renamed Fort Bones, as Gyrnar vowed to use necromantic science to ensure that the “bones of every Karn that had fallen would serve as a wall to protect those still alive.” Actual bones were not incorporated into the structure until it was rebuilt after the devastating assault in 990, when Valenar druids invoked an earthquake to

level the keep and what remained of the town. After a Karnathi reprisal, the bones of the slain elves were mixed into the mortar and the fort was rebuilt, a free-standing monument to death and necromantic innovation.

THE TOWN OF VULYAR

Far smaller than the cities that govern the western duchies, Vulyar is a useful intermediate point between the Talenta Plains, the Mror Holds, and western Karnath. The town's seemingly arbitrary location is due to a Risian manifest zone that bears the plane's powers of preservation; long ago discovered by travelers, it's now home to the town's grain silos.

CANNITH EAST FACILITY

With the construction of the Cannith East Facility in Vulyar less than a decade ago, Zorlan's ambitions have brought significant new business to the town. Viceroy Renilda d'Cannith (they/them) runs the facility, which produces conductor stones to be used in lightning rail construction throughout eastern Khorvaire. This work has attracted all sorts of supporting businesses, and—combined with the damage in western Karnath—has made Vulyar the fastest growing settlement in the nation.

Secretly, the facility's basement laboratories are an extensive joint operation with the Ministry of the Dead. These labs are a core part of Vedim's ongoing research, developing all sorts of malefic undead to be deployed against the elves of Valenar. The newest target is an ancient *taer* fewer than 100 miles to the southeast of Vulyar; Shan Shulach Miritarn of the Valaes Tairn is leading an effort to restore the fort, a provocative act that Count Vedim ir'Omik believes justifies a reprisal.

RISIAN GRAIN SILOS

While the Risian manifest zone in Vulyar is not particularly large, ancient travelers figured out this region was a safe place to store excess supplies throughout the year. Today, the Risian manifest zone has been designated for the exclusive use of storing the city's grain supply and other foodstuffs. While the manifest zone does protect from ordinary rot and decay, it doesn't help with vermin; a hubris of cats owned by the town government patrols the area for any would-be thieves.

TEMPLE OF THE SOVEREIGN HOST

A large, established structure, Vulyar's Vassal congregation places more emphasis on the Three Faces of the Wild than the Sovereign Host as a whole. While Vulyar is generally known for its bountiful fields, the risk of supernatural disasters from Mabar as well as the more mundane threat of wildfires make the Devourer a known figure in the area. Balinor sees a diminished role in the trio these days as hunting has become less common.

TEMPLE OF THE BLOOD OF VOL

A large, ominous pyramid built during the war, Vulyar's temple of the Blood of Vol sees far fewer residents in attendance than it once did. The former abactor that led the congregation was executed by the state in 976 for their ties to Lady Illmarrow; Mauriana Furnau (khoravar she/her) was unaware of her former boss's schemes and has led services since then.